All Eyes On Me

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32500876.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra)

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Appearances from a lot of other characters, Background Relationships, the usual, Fluff, Humor, Some angst, Mentions of various mental illnesses, Adora Has ADHD (She-Ra), (Former) celebrity Catra, Fame Sucks, Shadow Weaver is a terrible person, Depression, Anxiety, Wrong Number AU, there's a lot going on, OC Moms for Catra, Hurt/Comfort, talk about past abuse, nothing graphic, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, trans Catra, brief mentions of homophobia and transphobia

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English

Series:
Part 10 of Any Version of Reality

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Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables

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by catrasredemption (dimensionhoppingrose)

Summary

"*Glimmer!*" the drunken voice on the other end slurred. "*I need a ride. Mermista* left *me. Can you believe that?*"

What the *fuck*. Catra opened her mouth to speak, but the voice barreled on. "*And I forget my Uber password and Perfuma already left and pleeeeeeeeeeease come get me? I'll owe you big time. You won't even have to feed me when I help you guys move out. And I'll stop complaining about you abandoning me. And*"—

"Hey," Catra snapped, cutting her of f. "I'm not Glitter, or whatever. You've got the wrong number."

There was a pause, and then the other woman laughed. "*Good one, Glimmer! Seriously, it's cold, and I haven't seen any taxis…*"

"Did you drown all your brain cells?" Catra grumbled. "I'm. Not. Glimmer."

Another pause, longer this time. "*Oh no,*" the woman groaned. She sounded close to tears. "*Oh no, I must've mixed up the things in her new number. Oh stupid, stupid, stupid. I'm so sorry.*"

-OR-

The wrong number, drunk dial AU we all secretly need.

Notes

So this is a bit of an experiment for me - partially just posting something like this, and also because for the first time ever it's not completely written - the second chapter is only a few thousand words in and still going strong. But if y'all like this I mean... I can write fast with motivation

See the end of the work for more notes

Wrong Number, Right Time

It was two in the god damn *morning*.

Catra growled as she was ripped from sleep, reaching over to grab her cellphone. She didnt look at the caller ID, partially because she was still half asleep, and partially because she wanted to be bitchy without the prior guilt of knowing who she was snapping at.

"What the"—

"*Glimmer!*" the drunken voice on the other end slurred. "*I need a ride. Mermista* left *me. Can you believe that?*"

What the *fuck*. Catra opened her mouth to speak, but the voice barreled on. "*And I forget my Uber password and Perfuma already left and pleeeeeeeeeeease come get me? I'll owe you big time. You won't even have to feed me when I help you guys move out. And I'll stop complaining about you abandoning me. And*"—

She was clearly never going to stop. "Hey ," Catra snapped, cutting her off. "I'm not *Glitter*, or whatever. You've got the wrong number ."

There was a pause, and then the other woman laughed. "*Good one, Glimmer! Seriously, it's cold, and I haven't seen any taxis*"…

"Did you drown all your brain cells?" Catra grumbled. "I'm. Not. Glimmer."

Another pause, longer this time. "*Oh no*," the woman groaned. She sounded close to tears. "*Oh* no*, I must've mixed up the things in her new number. Oh stupid, stupid,* stupid*. I'm so sorry*."

She sounded so *sad*. Catra couldn't stay mad at her. "No, hey , it's okay." She crawled out of bed, ignoring the grumbling cat trying to insist she stay. "It' s fine, really. Where are you?"

"*At a bar*." That was helpful. "*Downtown*."

"Does the bar have a name?"

"*Probably*."

Catra slapped her forehead, sighing deeply. "What. Is. The. Name. Of. The. Bar."She spoke slowly , since that seemed to be the only way to get through to her.

"*Oh. Um.*" There was a pause, and a rustle of fabric. "*The Fright Zone. That's such a weird name. It's not even horror-themed*."

"Mmhm."Catra hummed, slipping her shoes on. "Super weird. So you said Glitter's abandoning you?"

She put her phone on speaker as she shuffled around, finding her shoes, then a jacket. It *was* a cold night. She grabbed a bottle of water out of the fridge as well. "*Huh? Oh, yeah, she's moving in with her fiancee. That's how. I mean, he already lives with us too. They're moving out together. I should be the one moving out, really, but they said they wanted their own place*."

"Fascinating."Catra wasn't entirely sure these people were *real*, but she went along with it. "So what has you out at"She got on the elevator, checking the time. "Two-thirty in the morning?"

"*We were celebrating. Spinny and Tossa got engaged. Everyone's getting engaged or dating.*"

There was a clear pout in her voice. Catra tried not to laugh. "Tell me about it. My friend just started dating someone and she will *not* shut up about it. Thank god our other friend is aro, we can be single together."

"*Aro? Like bow and? I have a friend named Bow*."

Catra stepped off the elevator, nodding to the young valet. He abandoned his phone and grabbed the keys to go get Catra's car.

"Aro like aromantic. She doesnt like people in a romantic way . Im not entirely sure she likes *people* at all, to be honest."

The woman giggled. "*That's nice. I wanna be aro. That's not a choice, right?*"

"Nope, it's just how she is. Kind of like someone being gay ."

"*I'm gay!*" Somehow , that didnt surprise Catra. "*So it's like being gay, except she doesn't like anyone?*"

"More or less." The valet pulled up with her car . Catra gave him a small smile as she climbed in, then plugged her phone in. The Fright Zone actually wasnt that far from her . It must have been fate. "You still in front of the bar, Princess?"

"*That's not my name*," the woman protested. Maybe not, but Catra reserved the right to call her that considering she was hauling her ass down to the bar to pick up this *complete* stranger. Absolute damsel in distress.

"Yes or no?"

"*Yeah, I'm still in front of the bar. I should hang up and call Glimmer, I guess.*"

"You dont have Glimmer 's number, remember?"

"*Oh. Right. I can call Bow . Or wait, he keeps his phone on silent. Hmm* "…

"Just stay on with me for like." Catra checked her ETA as she drove. "Ten minutes, okay?"

"*Okay! You're fun to talk to*."

"Youre probably one of the only people in existence who thinks that."

"*That sounds like everyone else's problem.*" Okay, she was starting to grow on Catra. "*Are you… arrow? Ay-row? Air… ay…*"

"No," Catra said before the woman got too lost in pronunciation. "Good old fashioned lesbian."

"*Aha!*" The woman giggled. "*All of my friends are gay. Well, queer. A few of them are bi. Perfuma and Bow dated for a little while, it was so* weird. *Glimmer was soooooooooo jealous.*"

"I'd be jealous too if my fiancee was dating another girl."

"*Nononono, this was in college, right before Glimmer and Bow started dating. She and Perfuma were in biology together, and she asked him out, and Glimmer was maaaaaaaaaad when she found out. Mermista told her it was her own damn fault for not asking Bow out herself. Anyway, they're engaged now and Perfuma has a girlfriend.*"

The more she said the name, the more it sounded familiar. *Perfuma*. Was that Scorpia's new girlfriend? How common could the name be?

"Well, it sounds like it worked out for everyone."

"*Yeah! Her girlfriend is really nice. I forget her name, but she gives* great *hugs*." Yup, that was Scorpia. "*She and Bow had a contest once to see who could hug the tightest. Everyone got hugs!*"

"Sounds fantastic," Catra said dryly, turning down the street the bar was on. The sidewalks were fairly empty – last call had come and gone – but there were a few people milling about. It took Catra a moment to zero in on the blonde woman standing alone in front of a bar. "Hey, are you wearing jeans and a pink hoodie with your hair in a ponytail?"

The woman gasped. "*Yes! How did you know? Are you psychic?*"

"No, I'm in the red car driving down the street in your direction."

Catra saw the woman's head snap around;her blue eyes sparkled in the dancing neon lights of the bar behind her, then lit up. "*You came to get me! Are you* sure *you're not Glimmer?*"

"Just get in the car , genius."

Catra stopped, ending the call, and the woman bounced in. "Oh wow, you're definitely not Glimmer . Thank you!"

She threw her arms around Catra, who bit down a groan. "Sure thing."She patted the woman' s back. "Just put your address in my phone and try not to get it wrong."

Her expression fell as she took the phone, typing very carefully. "Sorry ,"she said after a minute. "I have um.the math thing. The learning math thing."

"Dyscalculia?"

"Yeah, that. I mix numbers up a lot."That didnt give Catra a lot of confidence. She stopped to make sure the address was in a reasonable range, not wanting to find out too late she was going halfway across the city to an empty lot. It was only five miles down the street. Good. "I should've let Glimmer just put her number in my phone. Im sorry ."

"It' s okay,"Catra assured her . Honestly, this was all a *little* amusing to her. When was the last time she'd gone and had some spontaneous fun?"Hey , I brought you some water. Drink up."

"Oh."The woman found the bottle, draining half of it in one sip. "Jesus . "You're *so* nice. Thank you so much for saving me. W ait, is this why Im Princess?"

"This is *exactly* why you're princess,"Catra confirmed with a nod.

"Does that make you a knight?"

"Yup. A knight in leather armor."

"Cool." The woman fell silent for a few moments, juggling the water bottle in her hands. "You're cute."

Catra bit down a laugh. "You're not too bad looking yourself. Think you'll remember any of this in the morning?"

"I'll *definitely* remember the cute knight girl in leather armor." She sounded so sure of herself. "What about you?"

"*I'm* not drunk. Or likely going to forget this any time soon. It might be my new best story to tell at dinners with friends."

The woman pouted. "You're going to make fun of me, aren't you?"

"Relentlessly."

Thankfully, they pulled up in front of a building a few minutes later. "And you're *sure* you live here?" Catra confirmed before she unlocked the doors. The woman nodded.

"Absolutely, I've lived here for five years. Me and Bow and Glimmer. Cept I guess it's going to be just me now after this weekend."

"And you're sure you can get up to your apartment?"

"Yeah, I'm *fine*." Catra unlocked the doors, letting the woman out. She immediately tripped on the curb. "That doesn't count! I'm still fine!"

"Oooooooooookay," Catra drawled, rolling her eyes. "See you around, Princess."

"Thanks cute leather knight lady!"

This, Catra decided as she pulled away, had been worth leaving her bed for.

"Rise and shine!"

Adora groaned, rolling over and trying to slap the source of the sound. "Nuh uh. You're not getting out of helping us just because you're hungover. You knew this was coming."

"Glimmeeeeeeeeeeeeer ." It was definitely a whine. Adora didn't care. "Just a little while longer , please?"

"It' s almost noon. Also, I still *really* want to know how the fuck you got home."

Adora cracked one eye open to look up at her friend. There was poorly concealed amusement beneath her unimpressed irritation. "What'dya mean? Called you."

"No, *you* turned up drunk at the door around three a.m. and nearly knocked it down because you couldn't find your keys. The only thing I did was get you into bed." That was weird. Adora had a very clear memory of calling Glimmer. Okay, maybe *clear* wasn't the best way to put it. But she remembered finding Glimmer's name in her contacts and hitting *call*. "Now come on, seriously . We've only got the moving truck for eight hours."

"Fine, fine." This was going to *suck*. Adora dragged herself into a sitting position, reaching for her phone. She went to the call log, and sure enough, her last call had been to *Glimmer*. Was she just messing with Adora? That was mean.

Glimmer poked her head back in. "Also, Bow made bacon."

That got Adora out of bed.

Most of the day was lost in a haze of headaches and slight nausea and moving heavy things. She'd been hungover when they'd moved *into* this apartment too, and it hadn't felt nearly as bad. Was she already getting old? She was only twenty-five.

Bow and Glimmer took pity and didn't make her go with them to their new place to unload, at least. "Get some rest," Bow said, hugging

her tight. "And call if you need anything!"

"I'll be fine," Adora said with a small laugh. "Go do... whatever engaged couples do when they abandon their best friend."

"We're going like, ten minutes down the street," Glimmer said, rolling her eyes and trying to look like she wasn't almost ready to cry. This was the end of an era for all of them. "By the way, I looked at your phone earlier. You switched the last two digits in my number. I don't know who you called last night, but they must have been pretty pissed off about being woken up."

Adora didn't quite process those words until Bow and Glimmer were gone, the door closed behind them. "Wait… *what*?"

She ran back to her room, grabbing her phone off the charger. Glimmer had fixed her number, leaving the last entry in the call log as a random number with no contact listed in Adora's phone. A random number. Adora had called a complete stranger, drunk, at two in the morning.

Oh my god.

Calling the number went against every better judgment she had. But she needed to apologize, right? That would be the polite thing to do for a drunken misdial. She hoped the person wasn't *too* mad.

"*Morning, Princess*," an unfamiliar voice drawled. "*You just waking up*?"

Adora wanted to die. "Oh my god. I'm sorry... I'm so sorry. I was *so* drunk—"

"*I noticed*." The woman chuckled. There was a slight rasp in her voice that sounded vaguely familiar, but Adora couldn't place it.

"I hope I didn't bother you too much."

"*Ah, I crawl out of bed in the middle of the night for every stranger who drunk calls me. It's a big deal.*"

Adora's stomach dropped to her toes. "You. You came and picked me up?"

"*Well, you* were *hammered. Yeah, I drove you home. Figured I was doing the community a favor. The next person you drunk dialed might not have been so cool*."

"Should've just left me there to die." Adora groaned, covering her face. "I'm *so* so so sorry."

"*It's fine. I mean, I was pissed, but you gave me a nice ego boost. Seems like an even exchange*."

"I'll. I'll pay you for the ride."

The woman scoffed. "*I'm good, thanks. Don't need the money. This was my good deed for the year*."

Adora still felt terrible. "There's nothing I can do to make up for it?"

"*If you want to make it up to someone, my cat's pretty pissed that I got out of bed and left him. He takes only the finest catnip toys. Very high end*."

Adora laughed despite herself. "I'll start looking. Dont want a cat mad at me. That's bad karma."

"*Finally, someone who gets it.*" The woman sighed in mock relief. "*I'll be waiting for your offerings.*"

"Can I see a picture?" Adora nearly smacked herself. "I dont even know your name, and Im asking for pictures of your cat."

"*Well, I'm only sharing one of those, so I guess it's your lucky day, Princess*."

The line went dead. Adora stared at her phone for a moment, baffled, until a text from the number came in. There was a picture attached of an absolutely *massive* cat with long gray fur and vivid blue eyes. He was lying on his back, white belly exposed. Another text came in.

It's surprisingly not a trap. He loves belly rubs .

Adora couldn't resist responding. *He's so cute! Do I get to know his name?*

There was a long pause before an answer finally came. *Melog. He came with the name. I definitely would have called him something cooler*.

Adora tapped the number to make a new contact, listing it as *Melog's Human* 🐱👤.

That *should* have been the end of their interactions. Catra certainly meant for it to be. She wasn't vetting new friends at the moment, or ever. She was happy with what she had, thank you very much.

The rest of the weekend passed without incident. She put the blonde woman in her phone as *Princess*, just in case. But she highly doubted she would hear from her ever again.

So it was a surprise, Monday morning, when she woke up to an assortment of photos from Princess.

The flowers are blooming! I love this time of year so much .

The text was followed by a variety of different flowers, close up enough that Catra couldn't see any surroundings to make out where they actually were. Melog meowed loudly, settling himself on Catra's chest. She rolled her eyes and gave him an ear skritch before responding.

Kudos to whoever does the landscaping. Those are pretty nice

A reply came about ten minutes later, just as Catra was finally crawling out of bed.

I'll pass the message on. I work at a hospital, they try to keep the outside nice since the inside is usually depressing

Hospital? Catra raised an eyebrow, tapping out another reply.

Hospital, huh? Should I be calling you Dr. Princess?

Princess 👑

Lol! Lol, that's Glimmer. I'm just a physical therapist

WUT a physical therapist? Isn't that the person who like, helps people re-learn how to walk and stuff?

Princess 👑

Sort of, yeah. Or how to adjust with using prosthetics, or rebuilding muscle mass after being hospitalized for a long time. Stuff like that

Sounds pretty impressive to me

Princess 👑

I guess? I never really thought about it. Gotta go, though, talk later

It wasn't until Catra said bye that she really registered those last two words. *Talk later*. That was a bold assumption, wasn't it?

And yet, she found herself sending pictures of Melog periodically throughout the day. She had an instagram mostly dedicated to him (it *had* been hers, but it was basically obsolete, and Melog was a way better subject), so it wasn't like she had to work too hard to take pictures. It was just an extra step to text them.

Princess didn't *always* respond, but her responses were consistent coos of delight and *ohmygod he's so CUTE!!*

Catra's days consisted of a lot of doing nothing —sometimes she thought about going back to school (online, because in-person would be unbearable) but she had no idea what she wanted to *do*. Music? She laughed bitterly at the idea. That had been utterly ruined for her . And she'd never been interested in anything else.

"Catra?"

The sound of her mother 's voice broke her out of her daze. She'd been "watching" the Great British Bakeoff (letting it run in the background while she zoned out and stared at the ceiling), and at some point Netflix had stopped to ask if she was still watching, which meant the apartment had been quiet.

"Up here," she called, sighing. She should've known a "surprise" visit was coming.

Lyra made her way up the stairs, clicking her tongue slightly when she saw her daughter on the couch, still in her pajamas.

"*Please* dont start," Catra groaned, dragging herself off the couch. "I'm allowed to have pajama days, aren't I?"

"Not when pajama days are every day. Have you eaten?"

"Yeah." She paused. "I think. I had toast."

"I'm afraid to ask what your fridge looks like."

"I would be afraid too."

Lyra went to check anyway, picking out what she could for a decent meal. Catra knew her mother cared ~~-b~~oth of them did ~~-a~~nd surprise check-ins were their way of making sure Catra was taking care of herself. And they were right to worry. But she couldn't *tell* them that.

"You need to do some shopping," Lyra called from the kitchen.

"I always need to do some shopping."

There was enough there for Lyra to put together some pasta and chicken (from a can; Catra couldn't keep anything fresh in the apartment, and they both knew it). She set to work, and Catra put her show back on.

"Where's Mom?"

"Working late." Lyra shook her head. "I worry about her sometimes."

"She knows she could retire like, tomorrow, right?"

"Of course she does, but you know her ." The words *I'm not going to leech off my daughter like some monster* had been thrown around more than once. Even though Catra had offered, *repeatedly*, to just let them have the money they needed. It wasn't like *she* was doing anything with it, aside from random donations to charities and buying cat toys for Melog. "Anyway , she likes her job. She' s not leaving it any time soon."

"And you're here because you're lonely at home."

"I'm *here* to check on my daughter who clearly needs help feeding herself." Catra raised an eyebrow at her mother 's back. "And maybe the house was a little too quiet."

"Y ou need a pet."

"Why would I ever want a pet when I already have the best grandcat?" Melog had abandoned Catra at some point to wind around Lyra's ankles, purring loudly. She spoiled him with treats to make sure she was the favorite. "If I ask what' s wrong, are you going to be honest?"

"I'm always honest."

Lyra sighed. That was a no.

The problem was that there *was* no problem. Not any immediate problem, at least. Not anymore. But, as Catra's therapist had said a thousand times over, depression wasn't logical and didn't need a reason. It was just *there*, constantly hovering over Catra's shoulder like an unwelcome guest.

"W anna hear about something weird that happened this weekend?"

"Sure." Anything happening at all was amazing. L yra would take what she could get.

"I got this phone call at like, two in the morning. Some girl I don't know completely drunk off her ass. Apparently she mixed up a couple digits in her friend's new phone number and ended up with mine instead."

Lyra laughed. "You're kidding."

"Nope. She was calling to try and get her friend to give her a ride home. It was pretty funny, honestly."

"Do you know if she got home okay?"

"Dropped her off at her apartment myself."

"Really?" Lyra turned to raise an eyebrow. "You went and picked up a complete stranger at two in the morning?"

"Well when you put it like *that*, it sounds creepy. She didn't like, recognize me or anything, though. She babbled until I dropped her in front of her building and watched her to make sure she got inside. Then she called me the next day to apologize and ask if I knew how she got home."

"That drunk?"

"Oh yeah. I would've laughed more if she hadn't been so stupidly sincere about apologizing. She offered to *pay me* for the ride."

"Well, that was nice of her to think about." Lyra was quiet for a moment, focusing on the pasta. "Was she cute?"

"Mom!"

"I was just asking! It's been awhile since you had anyone new in your life—"

"And it's going to stay that way," Catra said firmly. "She's not in my life. She's just passing through. It's a fun story, that's all."

Lyra frowned slightly, glad her back was to Catra. She'd been extremely adamant about keeping people away since..everything. And Lyra didn't blame her . But she needed to open up again eventually. Shutting out the world forever wasn't healthy .

Neither she nor Cyra could think of a way to help their daughter, though. And they hated it.

"Do you need a break?"

The young man shook his head stubbornly , wincing as he dragged himself down the small path, inch by inch. Adora had her arms out, ready to catch him if he collapsed. Recovering from a spinal injury was the worst, and most people tended to push themselves.

The man made it back to his wheelchair without issue, though. He looked annoyed by how hard it had been, but Adora assured him he was doing well. Remarkably well, really.

"I wanna die," Glimmer groaned, slumping into Adora's office a few minutes after she sat down. She dropped dramatically onto the couch, one arm slung over her forehead, the other dangling pathetically.

"Definitely the wrong place for that. Have you tried the ER?"

"Yeah, they were firmly opposed to be dying there." Glimmer scoffed. "No idea why ."

"Probably makes their jobs a little harder . What's going on?"

"I've been here like, fourteen hours. People keep trying to die."

"Rude."

"That's what I said." Glimmer sighed deeply , closing her eyes. "Doctor Driluth's been here for the past day and a half, though. Ill

take my fourteen-hour shift over that."

"Sounds like things are crazy up there. How long has your dad been here?"

"Uh, since the day I was born." Glimmer scoffed. "I don't think Mom's even noticed. She's got some big case coming up. I'd say they only stay together for the kids, but"…

"But their only kid is a grown adult, and they actually do love each other even though they're workaholics?"

"That, basically. And Bow had the *nerve* to tell me I'm acting like them just because I stayed a few hours over! Can you imagine that? *Me*, acting like my parents. He's one to talk, he stays up until three in the morning grading papers. He doesn't even get *paid* for it. And all the in-class activities he plans are on his own time. At least we get *paid* if we work overtime."

Adora wanted to point out that they both worked too hard, but that would just round back to a discussion about *her* inability to admit she needed a break, and she didn't need that. Thankfully, Glimmer's pager chose that moment to go off. She grabbed it, and groaned.

"Someone's flat-lining. Gotta go."

"Good luck!" Adora called as Glimmer sprinted out of the office. She knew her friend loved her job and wouldn't trade it for anything. But they had all earned the right to complain about things every now and again, hadn't they?

The good part about being a physical therapist – no emergency could keep Adora passed her scheduled time. She waved to her co-workers, bag thrown over her shoulder, and went down to the cafeteria. The chances that Glimmer hadn't *eaten* in fourteen hours were relatively high.

She found her friend leaning on the nurses' station, staring blankly at the wall. "Got you food." Adora snapped her out of the her haze; she held up a sandwich and bottle of water. Glimmer groaned in relief.

"Marry me."

"I think Bow already beat me to that one."

"I mean, sure, *legally* you can't both marry me, but you could be like"…

"What, your side piece?" Adora laughed, shoving the sandwich and water at her. "Pass. Just eat before something else goes wrong. I'm heading home. *Alone*."

"You wouldn't have to be alone if you hooked up with me and Bow!" Glimmer sang to her retreating back. Adora rolled her eyes and pulled out her phone, stopping to wait at the elevator with a few other people.

Princess 👑

Glimmer just proposed to me.

Melog's Human 🐱👤

Damn, the good ones are always getting snatched up

I thought she was engaged to arrow boy

Princess 👑

His name is Bow. And how do you know that?

Melog's Human 

You basically told me your entire life story while we were on the phone and while I drove you home

Adora groaned, slapping a hand to her forehead. That night was going to *haunt* her.

Princess 👑

That's not fair, you know way more about me than I do about you

Melog's Human 

I mostly know that your friend group is a dating soap opera

Princess 👑

You have to give me SOMETHING

She stepped onto the elevator, watching her screen intently as the other woman typed.

Melog's Human 

My mom's a doctor

Princess 👑

Seriously????!

Melog's Human 

You said give you something! You didn't say WHAT

Besides I've been giving you pictures of my cat. Don't those make us square?

Princess 👑

But if I told you my life's story!

Melog's Human 

Okay maybe I exaggerated a little. Don't worry, I'll only use what I know to blackmail you if I'm REALLY desperate

Princess 👑

I am not at all reassured

"Hey Wildcat!" Scorpia called, waving so Catra could find her. Catra ducked her head, shoving her hands into her jacket pockets. She could *mostly* go out without being mobbed anymore, but there were

always a couple fanatics. Catra quickly found her way to a chair and sat, giving Scorpia's girlfriend an awkward smile. Perfuma was a perfectly… *fine* person, but she clearly belonged in the era of hippies.

"Hey Catra, wanna see what I'm working on?" Thank god Entrapta was there as a distraction. She already had a tablet out and was swiping through it to find details on her latest creation. Catra tried to listen, even if she didn't understand half of it, because *no one* could keep up with Entrapta. But she loved to talk. Catra could lend her an ear if it meant she didn't bring out the damn recorder again.

Nothing could stop Entrapta once she started, of course. The poor waiter struggled to get their orders. He was just walking away when Catra's phone buzzed, and she pulled it out without thinking. It was from Princess – a picture of a hand with a lady bug on it, with a text that read *Does this mean something good is going to happen?*

"Who're you texting?" Scorpia asked immediately. Catra groaned internally.

"No one"—

"The contact name is Princess with a little crown emoj," Entrapta observed. Catra quickly locked her phone. Perfuma looked delighted.

"You made a new friend!"

"No, it's just – for fuck's sake, why do you guys have to be like this?"

"I'm naturally curious," Entrapta said. "I believe Scorpia and Perfuma care about your well-being. As do I, of course," she hastened to add.

Catra heaved a sigh. "Look, it was a wrong number. She called me thinking I was a friend. She just likes it when I send her pictures of Melog, so I kept her number and send them to her. She's new, she

doesnt know about all the weird ass things he does. Her reactions are more fun to read than Instagram comments."

"So you're talking to some random person you dont even *know*?

"She doesnt know *me*, either," Catra pointed out. "Which means she doesnt know who I *am*."

"I can see why that would be attractive to you," Perfuma admitted. "But be careful."

Catra really did like Perfuma. She was observant, but sometimes it was a bit much. "It' s really fine. If I think things are getting weird, Ill cut her off. She doesnt even know my name. She calls me Melog' s Human."

"Accurate," Scorpia, Perfuma, and Entrapta said at the same time.

Princess 👑

Hey girl *Y lets you pet his tummy?!*

Melog's Human 🐱👤

Yup. He loves it

Adora pouted at her phone. Her mysterious friend has sent yet another picture of her cat - specifically , a hand giving him tummy rubs. She had *never* met a cat who indulged tummy rubs. She wanted to meet this cat. And maybe the person attached to that hand.

She hadn't brought it up, though, or even alluded to maybe exchanging *names*. The other woman seemed happy with their current arrangement, and Adora was enjoying it as well. It was fun getting to know her without any filters or expectations. And despite everything, Adora had learned quite a bit.

Her new friend was *not* an early riser. Her morning texts were grumbly, and pictures of Melog were usually taken of him snuggling her knees while they lay in bed together. She didn't have many friends - she had mentioned having a standing bi-weekly brunch date with three friends, but most of her plans seemed to involve staying home with Melog. It made Adora want to be her friend even more. She was absolutely, completely gay, and woefully single, which Adora could relate to, but she didn't seem interested in changing that. Adora didn't blame her . Dating sucked.

Princess 👑

Okay what if you just like, bring Melog over and leave him outside my door so I can meet him and pet him, and then I'll put him back out when I'm done and you can take him and we won't meet

Melog's Human 🐱🧑

Are you asking me to pimp out my cat?

How much are you going to pay?

Princess 👑

I don't know. How much do you think cat petting is worth?

Melog's Human 

He's a purebred Maine Coon, so I think it's worth a lot. Gotta feed that catnip addiction somehow

Princess 

Aren't Main Coons huge?

Melog's Human 

Yeah, this jerk likes to sit his entire twenty-pound body on my chest

What about a dollar per pound per hour?

Princess 

Isn't that just $2 an hour?

Wait, it is, right?

God I can't do numbers, I have the math dyslexia thing

Melog's Human 

Dyscalculia. You told me that already

Princess 👑

I DO Okay you owe me another fact about yourself, then

It took a long time for Adora to get an answer, and she started to get nervous. What if she'd pushed too hard? The woman seemed to enjoy her privacy. Adora didn't want to test her boundaries; she enjoyed talking to her too much.

But her phone finally buzzed, almost five minutes later.

Melog's Human 🐱🧍

I've got two moms

Being gay is basically genetically embedded in me

Adora laughed.

Princess 👑

Really? That's awesome. Bow has two dads, and they're great, but the dad jokes are RUTHLESS sometimes

Melog's Human 🐱🧍

Mom covers the dad jokes 😒 *Mama's the one who will mom you to death*

Princess 👑

You call them Mom and Mama? That's so cute!

Melog's Human 😺🧍

What? No! Shut up!

I just use that to tell the difference between them when I'm talking about them both

Who the hell are you calling cute?!

Princess 👑

You! And you ARE cute. You take pictures of your cat and send them to a total stranger, you call me Princess, you SPOIL your cat like he's your child, and you call your mother Mama. Certified cute

Melog's Human 😺🧍

Fuck you

I'm blocking your number

Princess 👑

orly?

Melog's Human 

Ugh, you're so fucking annoying

Princess 👑

Thought you were blocking my number?

Melog's Human 

I'm TRYING to but you're harassing me

Princess 👑

Likely excuse

Catra did not block Princess, of course, despite the downright *slanderous* language. Talking to her was too much fun, and it was doing wonders for her moods.

That didn't get by her mothers.

"You seem happy," Cyra said as she scritched Melog's chin. Lyra was in the kitchen making dinner, because she was convinced Catra couldn't feed herself. She wasn't completely wrong.

"Do I?" Catra's eyes flicked to her phone. She'd told Princess she was busy and wouldn't be able to talk for awhile, but she really wanted to text her.

"Is this about that girl you told Mama about?"

"*What*?" Catra's voice cracked. Lyra had betrayed her. Unsurprising. "No!"

Cyra raised an eyebrow, a small smile pulling at her lips. "Seems like denial to me."

"I'm not—I mean, yeah, I'm happy, but it has nothing to do with her!"

"Nothing to do with who?" Lyra asked, peeking out of the kitchen.

"Her mysterious new friend who also happens to be a girl," Cyra replied before Catra could.

"The one who called you by mistake? That was two months ago. Are you still talking to her?"

"No." Lying to her mothers was impossible. "Fine, a little. We just send each other pictures of things and talk sometimes. She doesn't know who I am, and it's just...nice. She doesn't look at me like I'm constantly about to break."

"We don't—"

"Yes, you do." Catra stood, wandering to the glass wall that gave her a spectacular view of Bright Moon's night skyline. "Regular parents don't go to their adult kids' apartments every weekend to feed them and make sure they're okay."

She could *feel* Cyra and Lyra exchanging a look behind her back. Melog meowed loudly, winding around Catra's ankles. "We worry about you," Lyra said after a moment. "That's part of parenting. It doesn't matter if the kid is five or twenty-five."

"You guys practically live here. Might as well sell the house and move in."

"Catra, we love you," Cyra said. "But I *never* want to live with you again."

The statement actually made Catra laugh. Cyra was good at that. "What your mother *means*," Lyra said sternly, "is that you've been independent for awhile now, and we wouldn't take that away from you."

"No, I mean I never want to fight her for the remote again."

"Tell me how you really feel, Mom."

There was no heat behind the words. Catra knew her mothers loved her more than anything. They'd never hesitated to support her and give her what she needed to live the best life she possibly could, and had nearly gone bankrupt trying to fight fucking Weaver for access to Catra's own bank accounts. Lesser parents would have snapped under that pressure.

"We love you," Cyra repeated with a little more emphasis on the words. "And we are *always* going to worry about you. That doesn't mean we think you're going to break. We know the kid we raised. Stubborn as a rock with a head as hard as one."

"*Cyra*."

Catra coughed down a laugh as Lyra scolded her wife. "It's fine, I get it. I love you both too."

She ended up sandwiched between her mothers in a tight hug.

Princess 👑

Do you work?

Adora *meant* it as an honest question—she really did. She was just curious; it seemed like Cat (her new name for Melog's Human,

because that name didn't roll off the tongue very well) had a lot of extra time and sent pictures of Melog at all times of day. It wasn't until she checked her phone two hours later and saw no reply that she realized how rude that question sounded.

Princess 👑

Omg I'm SO SORRY I didn't mean that in like a rude way or anything I was just curious about what you did, you know, because you know I'm a physical therapist, and I've talked about it a lot, but you never talk about your job

I'M SORRY

She had to abandon her phone after that, only getting back to it during her lunch break. Her sigh of relief was audible when she saw an answer.

Cat (Melog's Human) 🐱🧑

You're fine. I'm just not sure how to answer that

I don't, is the short answer

But there are a lot of complicated reasons

Oh. That sounded terrible. Adora frowned as she typed back a reply.

Princess 👑

Do you want to talk about it? I'm a good listener . Or reader. Or is it one of those "I can't get into it without telling you who I am and I don't want to do that" things?

The answer this time was immediate.

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Lol, you caught onto that?

Princess 👑

You're not exactly SUBTLE about it. And it's fine, I think this is all kind of fun - it makes me feel like a kid again. I've got a secret friend and we don't know each other but we're definitely best friends

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Whoa hey now , MELOG is my best friend. Don't put yourself above him

Princess 👑

Sorry, second best friend

Cat (Melog's Human) 

I have at least one other person applying for that position. Might be a tough fight

Adora assumed they were moving on from the work thing, and was attempting to take a picture of her biceps (it didnt matter if Cat saw her face, they'd technically met in person, even if Adora didnt completely remember), when another text came through.

Cat (Melog's Human) 

It's a lot

Princess 

Try me

The typing bubble appeared and disappeared at least six times, and there was no answer by the end of lunch. Adora let Cat know she had to go back to work, but to keep working on her answer and she'd read it as soon as she could.

That turned out to not be until the end of the day . She locked herself in her office for some peace and grabbed her phone to see what Cat had written.

Cat (Melog's Human) 

I've kind of been… "working" since I was 3. I really don't want to tell you what I did because it'll make it WAY too easy to figure out who I am, and like you said, I don't really want to do that. It's nothing against you, I swear. But like you said, having a secret friend is nice. We don't know anything about each other's baggage. You treat me like a normal person. My moms don't even do that. They love me, I know they do, but they think I'm fragile after everything that happened. Which I'm still trying to figure out how to talk about

So like I said, been working since I was 3. NOT doing anything illegal (well, I personally didn't do anything illegal). But the job was an amazing chance for me to do something I loved more than anything, and I begged my moms to let me take it. There was a lot of legal stuff involved, but I got to do it

It wasn't really what I thought it would be, though. I was basically a puppet for 8 hrs, and my moms tried to get me out of it, but like I said, legal stuff. They signed a contract, they had almost no control over my life. It's not their fault, the fine print was TINY

Anyway, the eight years were terrible, but I made more money than I'll ever know what to do with. My moms won't even let me help them pay for their house, it's a stupid pride thing with Mom. I buy them stuff sometimes, though. And I donate to charities. And I don't work because I hate going outside, there's nothing I really enjoy enough to want to do it as a job, and I have the money anyway, so why bother

I'm also an AMAZING tipper. Delivery people love coming to me

Adora read the entire thing three times to make sure she understood, then slowly started typing out an answer. She wanted to be as careful as possible.

Princess 👑

I'm sorry, that all really does sound horrible. You deserved better

She was trying to shake off the thought that Cat might be a celebrity of some kind – fame was almost never kind to people, and she knew childhood stars tended to have it worse. But she didn't *want* to think about it, because she didn't want to start prying for Cat's information, even accidentally. Also what were the chances that she would accidentally call a *celebrity* in a drunken haze? Never mind that person leaving their apartment at two in the morning to pick up a drunk stranger and take her home.

Cat (Melog's Human) 

It all really, really, REALLY sucked. Sometimes I think I'm over it, then something will come up that reminds me about it and I'll crawl into bed and want to die for three days

And yes, I've been to therapy and gotten all the happy drugs. Pretty sure my moms would've tied me up and strapped me to a chair in front of a therapist if I hadn't agreed. But meds can only do so much

Princess 

I know

I mean, I have ADHD and I've been on something or other since I was twelve, and it helped, but it didn't HELP, you know? It's like a railing. It's there to support you, but you still have to make the effort to walk

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Aww)

But thank you. A lot of people don't get it

Princess 👑

Thank YOU for telling me all of this. I know it must have been hard

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Actually it was kind of okay? Just talking about the bare details with someone who wasn't around when it all happened feels kind of therapeutic

I might have to pick up drunk strangers more often

Princess 👑

lol lol

Adora's office door rattled as someone tried to open it. "Adoraaaaaaaaaaa!" Glimmer called. "*Please* come over for dinner, Mom, Dad, George, and Lance are all coming over to see the new place and you *know* how my dad and Bow's dads get."

The cringey dad jokes. Adora winced. It was going to be a long night. "Coming!"

Entrapta had *betrayed* her.

Okay, *technically* she had just overslept her alarm and was running late, but the result was basically the same, Catra thought, her eyes fixed on her drink. Scorpia was *also* running late, but Perfuma managed to be perfectly on time, leaving the two of them alone with each other. Scorpia was late like nine out of ten times, though. Entrapta was *always* on time.

"Are you okay?" Perfuma asked, tilting her head. She was nice. She was perfectly nice. Catra didn't hate her. She was almost *perfect* for Scorpia.

But she didn't *know* her, and it made her nervous.

"Yeah. I'm fine."

Silence. This was it. This was how Catra was going to die. Her leg bounced, her heartbeat quickening just slightly.

"Has Scorpia told you I'm trans?"

"Huh?" Catra looked up, blinking rapidly. "Um...no, I don't think it's come up. That's cool?"

Perfuma hummed, taking a sip of her drink. "I was lucky. My parents were always supportive."

Something stirred in the back Catra's mind. "Yeah, supportive parents are great," she muttered, taking a sip of her drink just to have something to do.

"Your mothers sound absolutely wonderful. Scorpia talks about them a lot."

"They *love* Scorpia," Catra said with a snort. "And Entrapta, but they have to show it differently because Entrapta's...Entrapta. I'm sure they'd love you too. They're the kind of parents who should have had ten kids."

"It sounds like they're happy with the one they have, though."

Catra finally looked up, meeting Perfuma's eye. "What's this about?" Because there was no way Perfuma just wanted to talk about how *nice* Cyra and Lyra were.

"Well," Perfuma frowned lightly, trying to think through the best way to approach this. "I know you haven't always had the support you deserve. Do you feel like you've... missed out on anything because of it?"

Catra's heart was pounding in her chest. She did her best to keep her breathing even. "Like *what*?"

"I know your manager wouldn't allow you to be publicly gay. Is there... anything else she tried to cover up?"

"*You*." Catra shoved away from the table, chair screeching against the floor. "You—You don't know what you're talking about."

"You're right," Perfuma said quietly. "I don't. But if you need to talk to someone—"

"I don't," Catra snapped, standing. "I don't need to talk to anyone, and I *definitely* don't need to talk to you."

She nearly ran into Scorpia in her haste to get away. "Hey Wild—whoa, okay." Scorpia scurried out of the way, watching Catra go, then looked back at Perfuma. "What just happened?"

Perfuma shook her head, sighing. "I pushed something I shouldn't have. I'm sorry."

"Oh." The fact that Scorpia didn't immediately say *it's okay* was a huge sign in and of itself. "Yeah, there are... a *lot* of things she doesn't like talking about."

"So I've gathered."

It didn't escape Perfuma's notice, however, that Catra hadn't said *no*.

Catra's day started with the headline *Prime Records under investigation for more abuse accusations,* and only got worse from there.

It was the first thing she saw when, still bleary-eyed and lying in bed, she opened Twitter, retweeted by one of the few people she followed who *weren't* Scorpia (Entrapta didn't bother with social media). Like an omen. A flashing neon sign screaming *Danger!* She tapped the link and started reading.

Of course more artists had come out of the woodwork. Catra's successful case against them had opened a floodgate of former musicians and singers who had been driven into the ground by Prime Records until they burned out, and then were thrown aside, left to spiral into drug and mental health problems. The lucky ones had scraped their lives back together on their own. The unlucky ones.were unlucky . Catra tried not to think too much about it. She easily could've *been* one of the unlucky ones.

Her phone went off —unknown number . It didn't take a genius to figure out it was some kind of paparazzi outlet. She declined, put her phone on silent, and set it aside, rolling over to pet Melog.

It had been three years. Sometimes she was mad at herself for not just getting over it already . A lot of these people had *way* worse stories than hers —hell, some of their parents had been on board with company, letting them do whatever they wanted for the sake of making another buck, completely at the kid's expense. At least Cyra and Lyra had *tried* to mitigate the damage, even if there wasn't much to be done in the face of the contract they had signed. They tried. And Catra loved them so much for it.

And she was still *alive*. She should have been grateful for that alone. Not lying in bed and feeling sorry for herself.

Melog snuggled up close to her, settling against her in a way that half pinned her down. She chuckled weakly.

"Okay , buddy. Guess I cant move now ."

Cyra and Lyra werent going to let her get away with that for long. They arrived around noon to find their daughter half-doing in bed, still held down by her cat, and with her phone's browser opened to a startlingly long list of stories about the record company abusing their artists.

"Nope," Cyra declared, handing the phone to L yra and shaking Catra awake. She groaned, rolling over and tugging the blanket up over her head. "Up."

"Dont wanna," Catra mumbled. Cyra tugged the blankets away .

"That wasnt a suggestion. Y ou're not spending all day in bed."

Lyra busied herself with closing the news articles. She and Cyra had *very* different approaches to helping Catra;they were both good for Catra, but figuring out which one she needed was tricky. Today, they had decided to let Cyra take her approach.

"Mooooooooooooooom." Catra covered her eyes, groaning.

"Have you eaten?"

"I'm not hungry ."

"That wasnt the question."

Cyra shooed Melog off Catra's chest. Melog hissed, but grumpily moved to lie on an open spot on the bed. "Come on. Y ou need to eat."

That was L yra's cue to retreat to the kitchen and see if Catra had anything that would make a passable meal. She didnt. L yra sighed sadly at the bare shelves. This might be a good time to talk to Catra about therapy again.

Maybe not that *moment*, though. Cyra was dragging Catra into the living room;compromises had clearly been made. Catra had gotten up, but she was still in her pajamas and had her blanket hanging of f her shoulders.

"I'm going to pick up some groceries," L yra let Cyra know. She kissed Catra's forehead and left. Cyra cast a look around the living room. She grabbed a couple controllers off the entertainment center.

"T ime to teach me that cooking game," she said cheerfully , sitting on the couch. Catra whined and hid her face in her knees. Cyra nudged her, speaking in a gentler tone. "I know . It's hard when all of that gets dragged back up."

"It would be easier if you'd just let me stay in bed," Catra muttered.

"Maybe. But it wouldn't healthier , and you know that. So, teach me the cooking game?"

Catra looked up, sighed, and took the controller. "*Fine* ."

"Okay , let me know when you get here. Are you *sure* she wants me to tell them?..Good point. Okay , see you soon, lovebug."

Perfuma turned to her friends with a strained but determined smile on her face. Even Adora could see through that. She watched the woman clap her hands together and take a deep breath.

"So!Scorpia and her friends are almost here. Thank you *so* much for letting them come, first of all."

"The more the merrier ," Bow said. "They'd finally cleaned up their new townhouse enough, and wanted to have a belated housewarming party. Apparently Scorpia's friends didn't get out much, and she'd asked if they could join.

"Before they get here, there's something you need to know about one of them." Oh that didn't sound good. "She's a *very* nice person, I swear, but she comes off a little prickly sometimes and—"

"Perfuma," Glimmer cut her off. "I don't want to be a terrible person, but do we need to uninvite them?"

"No, no," Perfuma said quickly. "It's just... does *Catra* ring any bells with anyone?"

Bow choked on his drink mid-sip, shooting up from his relaxed position and coughing. "*Catra*?" he wheezed, voice cracking. "Like — Catra? Like 'after long enough my lips grow cold I can call your bluff but it just gets old' Catra?"

"Did you know that off the top of your head?" Mermista asked, raising an eyebrow. Perfuma bit her lip.

"Yes, that Catra."

Spinnerella looked between everyone, tilting her head. "So... who is this?"

"She *was* a singer until about three years ago—"

"It's one of those lucky life stories." Glimmer rolled her eyes. "She posted cover songs on YouTube and was '*discovered*' by some big label company. Bow *loves* her."

"Not like some creep or anything!" Bow said quickly. "It was something Adora could *only* believe coming from him. He didn't know how to be a bad person. "She was just really cool, and she's like, *our* age. It's awesome."

Perfuma looked deeply uncomfortable now. "That's... kind of why I'm telling you now. She doesn't like to talk about that. Any of it."

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "She's not some obnoxious, over-the-top former child star who thinks she's better than everyone just because

she won a couple awards, is she?"

"No," Perfuma said. "The opposite, really. I don't know the full story, and I haven't looked it up out of respect for her privacy." She looked to Mermista and Netossa as she said that part. They were both typing on their phones, and stopped when Perfuma called them out. "But some really terrible things happened when she tried to leave after her contract was up."

Bow sobered up a little, fidgeting and casting a look at his glass. "Yeah, it was all... really bad. I can see why she wouldn't want to be hounded."

"Good!" Perfuma let out a sigh of relief. "So no bringing up her music, or asking her for an autograph, or what it's like to be famous, or anything. Right?"

"Yeah." Bow nodded solemnly. "Of course, that'd be terrible to do to her. She's a guest."

Perfuma beamed. "Thank you. She's *very* important to Scorpia, and she really is a good person. The world just... hasn't always been kind to her."

Glimmer scoffed under her breath, but it went unnoticed as Perfuma's phone went off. "Oh, they're here! I'll be right back!"

"*...hasn't always been kind to her*," Glimmer muttered as Perfuma ran out. "She got famous when she was thirteen and has more money then she'll *ever* spend. I wish the world would be that unkind to me."

"Please don't," Bow said quietly. "I only know the public details, which isn't much honestly, but basically her manager was abusing her and controlling her entire life. Her parents had to sue the manager and record label for Catra to even get any of the money they made off her."

"Oh, I remember that," Spinnerella spoke up, frowning. "The paparazzi wouldn't leave the poor girl alone."

"It all sucked," Bow said. "Let's just not talk about it. There's no reason to anyway."

Perfuma returned with Scorpia and two other women – both short, although the purple-haired one was definitely the shortest. She was looking around in fascination, as if she had never seen a townhouse before. The other had her eyes locked on the ground, hands jammed in her jacket pocket.

Oh no, she's cute.

Adora ducked her head, making a sound that thankfully only Glimmer could hear. It got her a kick in return. Celebrity? Fine. Cute girl? Adora was useless.

"Hi guys!" Scorpia said cheerfully. She was a little… *much* sometimes, but she gave great hugs, and Adora could respect that. "Thanks so much for letting us come. This is Entrapta" – the purple-haired woman, "and Catra." The one with the pixie haircut that was *far* too cute to be allowed. "Entrapta, Catra, this is – whoo boy, there's a lot of people" –

"Let's get to know each other naturally," Perfuma said, taking Scorpia's hand and leading her to the couch.

"So, this is a house-warming party?" Entrapta asked, still looking around. "Why do you need people to warm your house? I guess natural body heat is a factor" –

"Entrapta, you're talking to people," Catra said, shooting her friend a look.

"Can I get you guys something to drink?" Bow asked, ever the gracious host. He started to stand, then paused on Entrapta, tilting his head. "Do I know you?"

"I don't think so? I don't spend a lot of time around people anymore."

"I swear you… *oh*!" Bow lit up. "You used to hang out at the Bright Moon makerspace, right? You built the robots that tried to take over."

Entrapta immediately straightened up, turning into a completely different person between blinks. "Yes! They almost banned me for that. Were you there?"

"I was hiding under a table scared for my life!"

"Why do you sound *cheerful* about that?" Netossa asked dubiously.

Entrapta joined Bow to get drinks while they happily recounted that day at the makerspace, leaving Catra alone at the door. "Come on, Wildcat." Scorpia waved her over. "Grab a seat." She looked at the rest of the room, grinning. "I swear these two would never see another person if I didn't drag them out. Entrapta basically lives in her lab, and Catra"—

"*Likes her privacy*," Catra said pointedly, leveling a flat stare at Scorpia.

"That doesn't mean you should *never* interact with people again," Scorpia replied without missing a beat. "This was clearly a song and dance they'd done before. Catra silently made her way to the couch, choosing to curl up against the side of it, knees pulled loosely to her chest. Scorpia looked satisfied as she returned her gaze to everyone else.

"I still have Darla and Emily!" Entrapta was saying cheerfully as she followed Bow back to the living room, carrying a couple drinks. "Worked out the bugs so they don't turn on people anymore. They still fight each other sometimes. It's kind of like having cats."

"That's *awesome*. Do you have pictures?"

"Bow teaches science," Perfuma spoke up. "And runs the robotics club."

"Well, the *kids* run it." Bow chuckled. "I just make sure they don't blow themselves up."

"That's harder than you'd think," Entrapta said seriously.

"Tell me about it."

Adora's gaze drifted to Catra as the others began talking. She looked extremely distant, as if her physical presence was all that was here. And her eyes looked so *familiar*. One was a bright, ocean blue, the other a warm amber. Maybe Adora had seen her picture in passing or something and the eyes had stuck with her. Heterochromia wasn't *exactly* common.

The topic eventually came around to work, which was mostly Glimmer moaning she wasn't going to survive her internship. "Hey." Scorpia nudged Catra. "Doesn't your mom work at Bright Moon General?"

"Oh, yeah." Catra leaned forward a bit to look at Glimmer. "Doctor Driluth?"

"I know her!" Adora said. "She's really nice."

"I *love* her!" Glimmer exclaimed. "All the other doctors with interns just like, assign them numbers and never get to know them, but Doctor Driluth actually *cares* and it's so nice."

"Sounds like Mom," Catra said dryly. "Shame she hates all her interns."

"*What*!?" Glimmed shrieked. Catra maintained a serious expression for about two seconds before she snorted.

"Nah, I'm fucking with you. Mom loves almost every intern she gets. She *gushes* about how proud she is of them whenever a surgery

goes well or they handle a difficult patient well or something like that."

"I love listening to her stories," Scorpia said happily. "They're always great."

Glimmer was still pouting a bit over Catra's joke, arms crossed tight across her chest. But the subject moved on, with the others chiming in about their own job problems. Mermista was in the middle of complaining that she was tired of being hired to find out if someone's spouse was cheating on them, and clearly love was dead (despite Sea Hawk's loud complaints) when Adora saw Catra cast a slow glance around the room. Her gaze lingered longest on Scorpia before she carefully pushed herself up and slipped out the front door unnoticed. Adora knew she should let it go, but the town house complex was kind of complicated, and she knew it was easy to get lost (never mind *how* she knew). It was that thought which drove her to quietly follow.

Catra was just outside the door, taking a deep breath; she jumped when she heard the door open, whipping around. Surprisingly, she relaxed at the sight of Adora.

"Sorry, thought you were Scorpia."

There was, Adora noticed, a slight tremble in her hands. "I was just worried you were going to try and get out on your own. This place is complicated."

"Yeah, Perfuma led us through from the street. I think I could get out if I really wanted, but it's not worth the hassle."

She ran a hand through her hair, clearly just give herself something to do. Adora hesitated for a moment before taking a chance. "So… how long have you known Scorpia?"

"Since kindergarten," Catra said with a scoff, but Adora could hear the fondness in her tone. "We used to live in Half Moon—you know,

one of those small-ass places where graduating classes are usually less than one-hundred. Scorpia found us on the first day of school and declared us friends forever."

"That's so sweet," Adora cooed. Catra almost smiled.

"Yeah. We lost touch for a few years, but when I found them again, Scorpia acted like she'd just seen me yesterday. She's annoyingly easy to get along with sometimes."

Adora laughed. "Bow's the same way. I moved to Bright Moon halfway through high school and he just scooped me and sat me next to Glimmer at lunch. Kinda hard to say no after that."

"He seems all right. Entrapta doesn't usually get excited like that because we never understand a damn word she's saying. Talking to Bow might be her best experience with humanity."

"Should Glimmer be worried?" Adora joked.

"Nah, Entrapta's aro – aromantic, I mean. Doesn't really go for the whole relationship thing."

"We were celebrating. Spinny and Tossa got engaged. Everyone's getting engaged or dating."

"Tell me about it. My friend just started dating someone and she will not shut up about it. Thank god our other friend is aro, we can be single together."

"Aro? Like bow and? I have a friend named Bow."

"Aro like aromantic. She doesn't like people in a romantic way. I'm not entirely sure she likes people at all, to be honest."

The words triggered something in the back of Adora's head — memories forgotten, or buried under a haze of alcohol. Aromantic. Why did that sound familiar?

Catra's expression was slightly startled, almost unsettled. She rubbed the back of her neck, saying, "We should get back inside before Scorpia thinks I ditched," then hurried passed Adora without another word. Adora stayed outside for another moment, slowly sliding her phone from her pocket and checked the last text she had gotten from Cat.

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Not gonna be around much tonight. Friend's dragging me out to do the social thing

Princess 

Try not to let it kill you)

She stared at the texts for a very, very long time. Then locked her phone and tucked it into her pocket.

She wouldnt push. Cat liked the arrangement she had now . She liked her anonymity. She liked talking to Adora because Adora *didn't* know anything about it her. And it could stay that way, Adora thought, looking up at the stars. She could put aside what Bow had told her ~~-it-~~ had been about as detailed as the story Cat had given her ~~-a~~nd keep talking the way they had been. Nothing had to change.

Adora would make sure nothing changed.

Escapes

Chapter Notes

> Mentions of transphobia and homophobia and brief appearance of Weaver. Drinking, slight implication of alcoholism.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Cat (Melog's Human) 

I'm sorry, you LIKE kale? Unironically? Nope, this friendship can't continue, sorry

Princess 

What's the dealbreaker? It's good!

Cat (Melog's Human) 

It is NOT good. It's nothing. It's AWFUL

Princess 

Didn't realize you were so passionate about it

Adora was giggling as she set her phone aside and took a bite of her lunch. It wasn't even their most ridiculous debate, but Adora had mentioned food, and it had all spiraled.

Cat (Melog's Human) 

You're not one of those weird health nut people are you? Like, you've eaten a pizza in the last year?

Princess 👑

Of course I have

Cat (Melog's Human) 

How many vegetables did it have on it?

IDK WHAT LETTUCE!

Princess 👑

If I say yes, are you going to respond?

(It hadn't, but Adora couldn't resist teasing.)

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Lol, I'm just going to throw up

Disgusting

"What are you laughing at?" Glimmer asked suspiciously as she sat beside Adora.

"Nothing." Adora shoved her phone back in her pocket, smiling innocently. She was such a bad liar. Glimmer just stared. "I was laughing at something stupid on Facebook. You'd judge me for it."

"Try me."

"Excuse me?" A voice interrupted, thank god. They looked up to see a tall, slender woman with sandy brown hair and curious blue eyes

standing beside their table. "Could either of you help me find my wife? She's about this tall—" She indicated a point near her shoulder, "brown hair that she swears isn't going gray, a wedding ring unless she's run off with that cardiologist"…

"I'm *five minutes late*," a second, exasperated voice broke in. Glimmer immediately sat up a little straighter.

"Hi Doctor Driluth."

"Spella," the doctor greeted her intern, and took the other woman's hand. "I hope my wife hasn't been harassing you too much."

"I was *just* wondering if your lovely intern knew"—

"If I ran off with the cardiologist?"

"Yes."

Cyra put a hand to her chest, feigning hurt. "Honestly, Lyra, you wound me. And here I was thinking about coming home tonight."

"*Really*." Lyra rolled her eyes, then threw a smile at Glimmer and Adora. "Take notes, this is exactly what you don't do if you want to keep a partner long-term."

"Oh, I'm not," Adora waved her hand. "I'm just a physical therapist."

"Just?" Lyra raised an eyebrow. "You went to school and got your degree and do it professionally, right?" Adora nodded. "There's no just about that. Give yourself a little more credit."

Adora blushed, ducking her head. "That was almost exactly what Catra had said—

Cat. Not Catra. They were completely different people, really. Speaking of… Adora grabbed her phone as the doctor led her wife to an empty table.

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Are you eating RIGHT now?

Princess

What if I am?

Cat (Melog's Human) 

I don't think I can talk to you right now

Catra was anxious.

It wasn't the same, all-consuming anxiety that had always hit right before she stepped onto stage in front of thousands of people. It wasn't threatening to drive her over the edge, into a panic attack.

But it was making her *jittery* . She'd spent four days since the party alternating between trying to occupy herself with video games and pacing her apartment;she'd even tried to pick up her guitar once. *That* had nearly triggered a panic attack.

She was waiting for the other shoe to drop. For Adora to realize the truth and call her out. Because there was absolutely no way she hadn't figured it out after that *stupid* slip Catra had made about Entrapta. She'd seen it in the blonde' s expression. She'd recognized it.

She knew.

But she hadn't *said* anything. It had been business as usual the next morning, with Catra sending a picture of Melog to Princess and getting the usual *Aw, good morning cutie!* in return. Maybe Catra had misinterpreted the look. Maybe Adora hadn't connected the dots.

Hell, what were the chances she even remembered that small bit of their conversation? Maybe Catra was giving her too much credit.

No. She knew. There was no way she didn't.

So why wouldn't she *say* anything?

Princess 👑

What about celery and peanut butter? Is that acceptable to you?

Cat (Melog's Human) 🐱👤

When was the last time you had chocolate? I'm worried about you

Another silly, pointless debate. Another fun conversation. Another day without Adora bringing up *by the way are you an ex-celebrity who had her entire trauma advertised to the world?* Each second that passed without the subject being brought up frayed Catra's nerves a little bit more. Why wouldn't Adora *just ask*?

Melog meowed loudly, snapping Catra out of the spiral. She clenched and unclenched her fists, taking a few deep breaths. She was fine. She just needed to relax. Maybe Adora really *didn't* know. Maybe she didn't remember the conversation. Maybe the look on her face had been about something else. She collapsed onto the couch, covering her face. Melog jumped down from his tree and walked along the back of the couch, headbutting the side of Catra's head.

"I'm thinking too much, huh?" she murmured, reaching back to scratch his ears. He purred, nuzzling into her hand. "Yeah, I know. Maybe I *should* go back to therapy."

I'm thinking about getting a pet. What's it like to have an animal as a roommate?

Cat (Melog's Human) 

It's like living with a lazy ass human who doesn't contribute to rent and screams to be fed at three in the morning

Princess 👑

Minus not contributing to rent, that's not very different from having a roommate who comes home drunk

It was *lonely* in the apartment, Adora thought ruefully as she walked into the kitchen, getting a fruit cup out of the fridge. Glimmer and Bow would drop everything to come visit, but it wasnt the same. Adora missed living with people.

Princess 👑

You're not looking for a roommate, are you?

Cat (Melog's Human) 

WOW, asking to move in before we've even had a date. You give lesbians a bad name

Adora choked on a grape. She hadnt even been *thinking*…

Princess 👑

WAIT NO

That's not what I meant!

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Uh huh. Suuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuure

At least ask me out first lol

Adora nearly threw her phone across the room. She wanted to *die*. Her face was burning red, and she was suddenly glad she was alone in the apartment—

Wait. She was *alone*. No one could see her. Including Cat.

And two could play at this game.

Princess 

Fine. Wanna go out with me?

Cat (Melog's Human) 

WAIT

Wow, you're REALLY desperate for companionship, huh? Maybe get a dog

Princess 

Is that a no?

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Going out with someone just to be their roommate is literally you know

It sounds like a terrible rom-com

Pretending to date just to live together

Can you imagine?

Adora smiled despite herself, assured that she had leveled the playing field. She popped a piece of cantaloupe in her mouth as she replied.

Princess 👑

Someone somewhere is already writing this movie. Who do you think they'll get to play me?

Cat (Melog's Human) 🐱🧍

Literally any generic blonde with blue contacts could play you, lmao

Adora was halfway through making a comment about Catra's eyes before she remembered she wasn't supposed to know that. Because she didn't really remember seeing Catra that night. And because this *definitely* wasn't Catra. She hurriedly deleted it and started over.

Princess 👑

The really important question is who they would get to play Melog

Cat (Melog's Human) 🐱🧍

There's no one cat in the world capable of encompassing Melog's energy

Princess 👑

True

You know that movie with the dead animals that come back to life? There was a zombie cat, and they had three different cats playing that role

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Weird

Melog is worth at least five cats

That was accompanied with a picture of Melog lying on a platform on a cat tree, limbs flung about as he slept. Adora giggled.

Princess 👑

I definitely need a pet

You might be right about getting a dog, though. Someone I can run with in the morning

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Of COURSE you run in the morning

Princess 👑

Why do you hate a healthy lifestyle so much?

Cat (Melog's Human) 

I just can't imagine it's any fun

Princess 

You could come running with me some time and see what you think

Cat (Melog's Human) 

There is no way for me to express through text how much I DO NOT want to do that

---

Cyra clenched her fingers around her phone, tight enough to break it, as she read the headline on the link Lyra had sent her.

Weaver pens new tell-all about working with Prime Records

She'd kill her. They'd never find her body. They had spent a *year* in court just to deal with Weaver, and now she was going to try and *profit* off Catra's grief and trauma? How dare she! Absolutely not, Cyra wouldn't allow it, she'd—

Her phone buzzed with another text.

Lyra

I can already hear you making murder plans

You know it doesn't help

No, it didn't. It helped even *less* that Cyra was currently stuck at work while her daughter was across the city, probably reading this article

because she had to torture herself for some reason. Was this even *legal*?

"I know that look," a low voice said. Cyra looked up to see Micah leaning against the break room counter with her, raising an eyebrow. "Need help hiding a body?"

"Maybe," Cyra muttered, showing him the phone. He read the headline a few times, eyebrows arching higher and higher as his eyes moved.

"Is that legal?"

"I'm going to damn well find out." She took her phone back to copy the link and send another text. "I know Angie is busy right now , but do you think she could recommend someone if it comes to it?"

Micah scoffed. "You know perfectly well she'll drop everything to help you."

She would, and Cyra *did* know that. Angella had been absolutely amazing to them throughout the original case, and every single lawsuit that followed. "I also know there are plenty of other qualified people in her firm, and she's *supposed* to be learning how to delegate."

"And you can guess how well that's going." Micah's smile was exasperated, but fond. "I'm surprised she hasn't already reached out about it."

"She might have called Lyra." Cyra shook her head, sighing. Micah watched her for a moment.

"Speaking of delegating, it might not kill you to do a little bit and go see Catra. I hear you have some *amazing* interns."

Cyra snorted, half laughing. "Yes, I'm sure you're not thinking of one *particular* intern at all."

"Can I help it if my baby girl is the best in her class?"

Cyra's phone buzzed again, pulling her back to reality.

Lyra

Elevator's locked

Of course it was.

Catra was ignoring her phone.

Cyra and Lyra were both calling her, and she knew one of them (probably Lyra) had tried to access the elevator. But she'd beaten them to that. Security could always override it, of course, if Lyra could convince them it was an emergency. But it was fine. Catra wasn't going to do anything to herself. Right?

She didn't know. The uncertainty was scary.

The bitch is going to write a book. A fucking book. *She could write anything. It doesn't have to be true, no one is going to fact-check shit. She could tell the world I have a massive drug problem, or that I tried to beat her with a baseball bat, or….*

The line of thought drifted off, then into something utterly horrifying. *She could out me*.

Catra's world narrowed dangerously as her breathing grew ragged. She doubled over, resting her hands on her knees, squeezing her eyes shut. She'd already staved off several panic attacks, but each one was getting harder to fight. She could have *help* if she just unlocked the elevator, but the idea of seeing her mother right then made her feel sick. She didn't need the pity or the outrage or the

promises that this wouldnt happen or the gentle handling like they were touching something ready to break. She was *tired*, and she needed someone to just treat her like a normal person for five minutes so she could think.

Breathing was still somewhat difficult as she stumbled to the couch and fell onto it, grabbing her phone. She ignored every missed call and voicemail and text message, going to one specific thread and pulling it up. And she began to type.

Cat (Melog's Human) 

You're the kind of person who eats baby carrots for fun, aren't you?

Adora stared at the message for a long moment. It was a little *hard* to avoid the news about Catra's old manager, and Cat had gone suspiciously silent about three hours ago while they had been exchanging cute puppy pictures they found online. Now she was back with this utterly random and nonsensical question.

Princess 

They're a good and quick snack!

She wanted to ask if Cat was okay. If she needed to talk. If she needed anything.

But she also wanted to respect that Catra *wanted* to maintain her anonymity here, with Adora, for as long as she could. It was a tricky line to balance.

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Smdh. I'll pay you ten dollars to go to McDonald's right now and eat a large fry

Princess 

I'm not a Toad!

I love McDonald's fries. It's a weakness

She wanted a distraction. Needed one, probably. Adora could do that for her.

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Really? Even your taste in crappy fast food sucks. Everyone knows Wendy's has the best fries

Princess 

Eeeeewwww, no. Too salty

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Oh, that's what makes them GOOD

Princess 

If I wanted to eat the ocean I would just go to the beach

Also I get salt all over my hands when I eat them. I hate it

Cat (Melog's Human) 

You know what, that's fair. I can respect that

Princess 

But you can't respect kale?

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Kale doesn't deserve respect

Catra chuckled, scrubbing her eyes. This was *exactly* what she had been looking for. A few minutes to just not think about things. To be *normal*. To clear her head before she had to deal with her mothers, or reality.

Princess 

What did kale ever do to you?

Cat (Melog's Human) 

First

She scrubbed her eyes one more time, blew out a long breath, then went to the elevator to unlock and texted Lyra.

Catra

You can come up now

Adora was worried about leaving her phone, but Cat stopped texting her right before her first patient came in. She could only assume that things were okay, and let Cat know she was going to work before leaving her office.

She did her best to focus, because bad things could happen if she wasn't one-hundred percent focused, but it was hard not to let her mind drift back to her phone. To Cat. Catra.

What if I just tell her? We can still just have stupid food debates, but I can ask her if she's okay.

But that's exactly what she doesn't want, isn't it? She has people who can ask her if she's okay. She wants someone to just have stupid food debates with.

Am I doing the right thing?

That was the question that followed Adora all the way to lunch. This was what Catra wanted—anonymity. Someone who didn't know her baggage. Someone who could treat her like she was a completely normal person. But even completely normal people had people who worried about them. And Adora wanted to be *that* for Catra too. She wanted to be someone Catra could lean on, not just someone who helped Catra escape reality.

Cat. Catra. Adora shook her head as she settled in the cafeteria with her lunch. It was getting harder and harder to properly distinguish the two.

Because they're the same people.

Adora ignored the voice in her head.

"You're *still* talking to that girl who drunk dialed you six months ago?"

Catra jumped, quickly hiding her phone and whirling to glare at Scorpia. "What? No! Shut up."

Scorpia just stared at her. It was brunch day, but Catra (understandably) hadn't wanted to leave her apartment, so her friends had come over instead. Perfuma was the only one actually capable of cooking, though. Scorpia ducked in and out to help where she could, but mostly she was making sure Catra didn't sneak off to hide in her room during her mandatory bi-weekly social time.

"So that *wasn't* Princess I saw on your phone?"

"Why're you looking at my phone?"

"I was curious! So *are* you still talking to her? Do you know her name yet?"

Catra just grumbled and went to join Entrapta on the couch. She didn't want to talk about any of it. Adora — *Princess* — was, for better or worse, still her one safe place. Even *Entrapta* was giving her pitying glances now. Catra needed to not ruin things with Princess.

"Food's almost ready!" Perfuma called. "Lovebug, can you set the table?"

"Coming!"

Catra did her best not to roll her eyes. She knew Scorpia loved the pet name, even if it was absolutely ridiculous.

"*Have* you learned her name?" Entrapta asked, tilting her head.

"Not you too."

"It's fascinating, is all. You've been communicating with her for months now, and you still don't know her name, and she doesn't know who you are? It's such a unique relationship."

"Are you studying psychology now?"

"Time to eat!" Perfuma called before Entrapta could answer. Catra happily escaped to the table. She didn't want to talk about Princess Adora. Her name was Adora. Her name was Adora, and Perfuma knew her personally, and that was dangerous. That made it all *real*.

And Catra was enjoying the fantasy too much to let it go now.

"Hey. Scorpia?"

It was time for another monthly together with her friends, which meant Adora was seeing Scorpia and Perfuma for the first time in awhile. She fidgeted uncertainly with her glass (soda, because she was *not* making another drunken mistake, never again) as Scorpia turned to look at her.

"Yeah?"

"I was um. I was just wondering how Catra's doing? I mean, I saw that thing about her old manager, and"…

"Oh." Scorpia wilted slightly. "Yeah, she's. she's doing okay. She's actually been letting me spend more time at her place when her moms aren't around."

So she wasn't alone. That was good. "Is that actually *legal*?" Mermista spoke up, leaning over to look at Netossa (their resident junior lawyer) and Glimmer (the daughter of the best lawyer in the country). Netossa shrugged.

"There's a *lot* of hazy gray area around this type of thing. She can absolutely fight it, though."

"She is," Glimmer spoke up. "My mom's taking the case. I guess she helped with the original case too? I wasn't home when any of that happened, though."

Adora slid her phone out of her pocket to check it. There were three texts from Cat—one of a jar of peanut butter and celery, followed by the word NO, and one of the same peanut butter and Oreos. Adora rolled her eyes.

Princess 👑

What a waste of perfectly good celery

Cat (Melog's Human) 🐱👤

Ah, my friend's girlfriend is one of those hippy vegan types. I'll give it to her

She didn't notice Perfuma's eyes on her.

It was raining when they broke up for the night. Adora bit down a groan. She'd walked here, of course.

"Need a ride?" Perfuma asked cheerfully. Adora blew out a long breath.

"Would you mind?"

Perfuma led Adora to her car; they got in right before it turned into a downpour. "My balcony plants will be happy," Perfuma said, watching the rain for a moment. "They always perk up a little more when it rains. It's better for them than tap water, that has too many chemicals in it."

"Um...right," Adora said. Perfuma started the car, carefully pulling out of the parking lot.

"It was kind of you to ask about Catra," she said after a moment. "She really is very nice. She just... makes it hard to get close to her sometimes."

Not if you call her while you're drunk at two in the morning. Adora was probably an exception to that, though.

"When was the last time we all got together?" Perfuma asked suddenly. The abrupt topic change gave Adora whiplash.

"Uh... like *all* of us? The night before Glimmer and Bow moved out." She wouldn't forget that hangover any time soon. "We were celebrating Spinnerella and Netossa getting engaged."

Perfuma hummed, focusing on the road. "I was supposed to drive you home, wasn't I? But Scorpia didn't feel good, so we left early."

Adora's phone went off; she quickly grabbed it, and saw a picture of Melog, along with a text.

Cat (Melog's Human) 🐱👤

Melog demands attention. Tell your friends you have to go

They stopped at a stop light. Perfuma couldn't see the text, but she could definitely see the picture of Melog. A small, knowing smile pulled at her lips. Adora met her gaze, shoulders falling.

"How long have you known?"

"Catra mentioned it months ago." The light turned green, and they started forward. "I didn't really put it together until tonight, though, honestly. How long have *you* known?"

"Since Glimmer 's and Bow's housewarming party." Adora sighed. "But she *likes* having someone who doesn't know anything about her."

"I know . And I can certainly understand it, especially with… *everything* that's being dragged up now." Perfuma pressed her lips into a thin line. "She' s having a hard time, and I think she enjoys the escape."

"I sense a but' coming."

Perfuma shook her head. "Catra' s made it clear I don't have any place in her personal business, and I can respect boundaries. Honestly, it's a little relieving to know the person on the end *isn't* trying to hurt her. Scorpia's been worried."

"Are you"—

"I won't tell Scorpia, no. And I won't tell Catra I know . This is between the two of you."

Adora smiled uncertainly. "Thanks, Perfuma."

She texted Catra back as they pulled up in front of her apartment, and she got out of the car.

Princess 👑

Getting home now. I didn't know Melog was so needy

Cat (Melog's Human) 🐱🧍

Clearly you've never owned a cat

"The short answer is that yes, technically this is *allowed*, but there's a limit to what she can legally publish."

"That won't stop her," Catra muttered, curling in tight on herself. Angella, Cyra, and Lyra looked back at her. They had settled at her kitchen table to talk while Catra stayed on the couch, legs tucked under her chin.

"Is there something she *could* expose that you don't want getting out?" Lyra and Cyra exchanged glances, then looked at Catra. She didn't answer. "You know I want to help, Catra—"

"But you can't if you don't know the whole story. I know," Catra muttered, pushing herself off the couch. She didn't have anywhere to go; she just wandered aimlessly, clenching and unclenching her fists. "It's not that I don't want it to get out," she mumbled after a moment. "But… *she* took that choice from me. I don't know how to take it back."

Angella nodded slowly. "And you don't want her announcing it and taking it from you again." Catra crossed her arms tight, staring at the floor. "We can sue. We have more than enough ground for that."

"Does that mean more court?"

Catra looked so *tired*. It hurt her mothers to see it. It wasn't fair. None of this was fair. "Unless she agrees to settle, yes," Angella said quietly. Catra seemed to deflate.

"I *can't*." Her voice was small and weak. "Please. There has to be something…"

She drifted off when she saw the sad look on Angella's face. There was nothing. She could fight it, or she could let this happen.

Or she could beat Weaver to the punch.

"You will not *tell anyone about these… defects."*

"Excuse me"—

"How dare"—

Ms. Weaver held up a hand, cutting off Cyra's and Lyra's furious protests. "We will take care of any medical needs, of course. But it is not *to be made public. This isn't a request. You signed a contract. You represent the label now. We have an image to keep. You're responsible for keeping it. Do I make myself clear?"*

Catra opened and closed her mouth a few times before turning to look at her mothers. They just looked stunned.

"Yes, Ms. Weaver," she muttered, eyes downcast.

Catra ran her hands through her hair, tugging at the short strands. Lyra went over to collect her in a tight hug. Cyra looked at Angella.

"Please," she said quietly. Angella nodded.

"I'll do what I can. I promise."

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Have you ever had a secret so big that it didn't even feel like your secret anymore?

Like, you'd be betraying someone else if you told it?

Adora stared at the texts, swallowing. Yes. She knew exactly how that felt. She wasnt sure how to respond, though.

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Sorry, thinking too much. Nevermind

Princess 👑

Oh, it's okay. Can I help?

Cat (Melog's Human) 🐱👤

I'm not sure. I don't think so

Princess 👑

Would telling me violate the "we don't know each other and we're keeping it that way" thing?

There was a long, long pause. Adora was looking at local shelters, trying to find a dog, and worrying that she had crossed a line, when Cat finally answered.

Cat (Melog's Human) 🐱👤

I don't know

Maybe

How's dog hunting going?

Adora bit her lip. She wasnt sure if this was a good idea. But she didnt want to push, either .

Princess 👑

Not bad. Look at this one. How cute is that name?

Cat (Melog's Human) 🐱🧍

If you get a dog named SUNNY I will seriously never speak to you again

Princess 👑

You say that about everything

Have you ever considered being less dramatic?

Cat (Melog's Human) 🐱🧍

I have, and I'm insulted that you would say such a thing about me

Adora rolled her eyes fondly. She knew she was smiling, a weird smile that had Glimmer *convinced* she was secretly dating someone. But that was ridiculous. Even if she wanted to...and okay maybe she did a *little* – Catra wouldn't go for it. They'd have to meet in person. That would make this whole thing real.

"*She's having a hard time, and I think she enjoys the escape.*"

Adora couldn't take away that escape just because of some stupid *feelings*.

Scorpia was surprised when Catra asked for Perfuma's address, but happy to hear that Catra was trying to socialize more. Perfuma didn't seem particularly surprised when Catra turned up a couple days later.

"Catra! It's so nice to see you. Come in."

Catra had her hands in her pockets, shoulders hunched, as she made her way inside, looking around. There was an entire wall of plants near the windows, getting a good dose of sun, which lit up the entire living room.

"Is there anything I can help you with?"

"Um." Catra looked around, shoulders hunched. "Remember when you asked if there was anything else Weaver made me hide?" Perfuma nodded, gesturing for Catra to sit. "It's complicated."

Perfuma sat with her. "Do you want to talk about it?"

Not really. But she needed to start somewhere. "I was thirteen when I started, and I... Weaver was mad at first about me *tricking* her, but I was *passing* enough that she could work with it. But I wasn't allowed to *talk* about it. And it sucked a little, but I thought... I dunno, I thought it would be all right? I mean it's not like she was forcing me to be a boy"—

"She was making you hide an important part of your identity," Perfuma said quietly. "That's not okay."

"But she let me *be*. They paid for hormones and surgery when I wanted it, and they... I mean, they were protecting me, weren't they? People are terrible sometimes, but no one ever got the chance to hurt me because they didn't know"…

"You could say the same thing about being gay," Perfuma said. "They protected you from homophobia by not letting you be openly gay. That made you miserable, though, didn't it?" Catra didn't answer. "And you still can't say it. They stole something from you, and you still haven't been able to take it back."

"It sounds worse when you put it that way," Catra muttered in a weak attempt at humor. Perfuma gave her a small smile, indulging the

moment.

"You're safe from them now. You know that, right? They can't hurt you."

Catra blew out a long breath, nodding. "I'm trying. I've been trying. This"…

"This is a lot," Perfuma finished the thought. "You've spent a lot of time pushing this away. You need time to come to terms with it again. That's okay. You know that right? You can take time. You don't have to make all your choices and do everything in one day."

That was what Lyra said, too. Her moms probably *would* love Perfuma. "And I know it's hard to even talk about. I'm proud of you for coming to me."

"It's not that big of a deal," Catra said, eyes on the ceiling now.

"It's hard to be vulnerable. And putting yourself out like this is about as vulnerable as you can be."

Catra chuckled dryly. "Putting myself out. Fitting."

Perfuma nudged her shoulder, smiling. "Maybe start small. One person you trust. Scorpia and Entrapta know, right?"

"You know," Catra tilted her head. "I'm not sure. My moms let me start experimenting young—you know, even if it was a phase, all we did was let my hair grow out and got new clothes. But my kindergarten teacher constantly deadnamed me, and I had to tell them that the teacher *thought* I was a boy. But we were like…five. It's not something we ever really talked about."

"So maybe start with talking to them about it? You trust them more than anyone, and they already love you for who you are."

Catra picked at her cuticles, nodding slowly. "Yeah. I guess that could work."

“And if there’s anyone else you feel safe talking to, you can always reach out. People who care won’t mind.”

There was a knowing glint in Perfuma’s eyes that Catra didn’t question. Perfuma was just weird sometimes.

“Yeah. I know.”

Princess 👑

I ĐUŁĦPĘŘŦŐG

Cat (Melog’s Human) 🐱🧑

…

…

…

Are you kidding

I hate this

I also love it

Adora beamed. She was looking at petfinder websites, and had come across a particularly adorable puppy labradora/pitbull mix with black fur and white spots on her billy. She was still growing but probably going to be a *big* girl. And her name was *Princess*.

Princess 👑

She checks every box! She's young and going to be big, she's active, and she likes to snuggle!

Her name being Princess is mostly a bonus

Cat (Melog's Human) 

I hate how cute that is, actually

Adora sent the link to her email and opened it so she could start filling out the application.

Princess 👑

Just you wait. I'm going to send SO MANY PICTURES of Princess

It's going to be adorable

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Do I have call you and her Human Princess and Dog Princess now?

Princess 👑

You COULD just promote me to queen

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Lol, I'm not contributing to your ego like that

Princess 👑

Rude (

Adora was laughing as she typed. She'd told Glimmer and Bow about her plans to adopt a dog, and they had been supportful — Bow had even offered to dogsit when Adora was at work since summer vacation was starting soon and the new dog might be nervous alone during the day — but Glimmer had been noticeably doubtful, wondering if Adora should start with something more low maintenance. Catra, on the other hand, had been completely on board, and even sent Adora links to shelters and foster dogs she thought might be good (or were just cute and deserved attention). Heck, adopting an animal had been *her* idea. That made Adora feel good. Supported. Believed in.

Cat (Melog's Human) 🐱🧍

Hey, so are you really doing this?

Princess 👑

Filling out the application now, why?

Cat (Melog's Human) 🐱🧍

What's your apartment number?

Well that was a slightly disconcerting question. Adora put her laptop aside, frowning.

Princess 👑

Why do you want to know that?

Cat (Melog's Human) 

I mean, I already have your full address, and I guess I could address a package to "blonde dumbass" and it'd probably find you, but I want to be sure

Princess 👑

Wait, what?

Cat (Melog's Human) 

I'm buying you pet supplies, idiot. Have you ever owned an animal? Do you know what you need besides food?

Princess 👑

Okay, first off, rude

Second, what? You're not buying me things!

Cat (Melog's Human) 

I have some extra money burning a hole in my pocket. Let me do something good with it

Adora stared at her phone for a long moment. Catra wasn't *wrong*, she already had the building address, and she could probably find her apartment number easily enough if she tried. But she was *asking*. She wanted Adora to trust her with that information.

Princess 👑

Fi

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Cool

Adora got the approval email for Princess a few days later. The day after, she got a huge package addressed to *Bonde Dumbass*, full of dog supplies, including a large bed, treats, chew toys, treat puzzle toys, several types of bowls, brushes and cleaning supplies, a lint roller, and a spray for helping with pee stains in the carpet. Adora took a picture of the address label and texted it to Catra.

Princess

wow, thanks

Cat (Melog's Human) 

)))

Angella's look was something close to *pity*. Catra looked away, glaring out the window. She *hated* pity. And she sure as hell didn't need it from her *lawyer* of all people.

"That was illegal," Angella said after a moment. "You know that, right?"

"They all did a *lot* of illegal things," Catra muttered. "Weaver was just the one carrying it all out."

And that was why the label was still operating. Even if their reputation had taken a nosedive, they'd managed to retain enough of loyalty to keep going.

"But there's nothing stopping Weaver from talking about it in a book, is there?" Cyra asked nervously.

"There are no repercussions that I'm aware of for forcefully outing someone — *legal* repercussions," the lawyer added pointedly when she saw the look on Cyra's face. "Murder for any reason is still illegal."

"It's only illegal if you get caught."

Angella raised an eyebrow, then looked back at Catra. "Are you certain she'd put it in a book?"

"No," Catra admitted. "But there's nothing *stopping* her from including it, right? And she could turn it into a sob story to make herself a look good — she *protected* this messed up kid from the big bad media company, and the kid turned on her for it."

"You've thought about this." It wasn't a question.

"Of course I have." She'd thought about a *lot* of things during the long nights when she couldn't sleep.

Her phone buzzed. She stood without a second thought, grabbing it and walking away from the table. It was a picture of Adora's new dog — *Princess*. Catra still couldn't believe it. The puppy was rolled over on her back, belly exposed. Another picture came through of a hand scratching the belly.

Princess 👑

She's so CUTE

Catra took a picture of Melog lounging on his cat tree and sent it.

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Melog is unimpressed.

Princess 

Has Melog been impressed?

Cat (Melog's Human) 

Maybe? Idk

"Catra," Lyra prompted gently. She looked back at her mothers and Angella, grimacing slightly.

"I... I can't do this right now. What's the *point*? She's going to do whatever she wants, she always does. She's going to fuck up my entire life *again*, and there's nothing I can do about it. Oh, except do it before she can, of course. I'm fucked either way."

"That's not—"

"True?" Catra cut Cyra off. "Yes, it is. She's always going to win. I don't know why I thought I could escape."

She turned away, walking to her bedroom without another word.

Karma was a bitch.

Adora jerked away as something thumped loudly on the front door. Princess whined in her crate, turning anxiously and pawing at the door. The loud noise was bothering her.

"Sssshhhh," Adora murmured, dropping a toy through the slits in the top of the crate to keep Princess busy while she walked to the door. She looked through the peephole, but all she saw was bits of hallway through distorted, fuzzy hair. Like someone was leaning on the door but not purposely covering the view. She grabbed her baseball bat, undid the chain and latch, and carefully opened the door just enough to look out into the hall.

"Heeeeeeeeeey Adora."

The slurred voice caught her off guard; she lost her grip on the door, and Catra stumbled through, laughing. Her eyes were bright and slightly glazed. "Catra...?" Adora said uncertainly, dropping the bat to grab her and keep her upright.

"Mmph," Catra mumbled into her shoulder, giggling. "Sup, Princess?"

"What... What are you doing here?"

"I uh." She waved her hand uncertainly. "I went out and drank a little, and I forgot my home address, but I remembered yours! So I gave that to the Uber driver. You owe me anyway."

It had been a few days since Adora had heard from Catra – the longest they'd gone without speaking since the day they met. Adora had reached out to Perfuma, who assured her that Catra was okay, just dealing with some things, and she would text when she was ready.

Apparently she hadn't been patient enough to wait for a text.

"Are you okay?" Adora asked, helping Catra straighten up and letting her lean against her.

"I'm greaaaaaaaat."

No, then. Adora walked her to the bedroom, carefully helping her into bed. "Oooooh, are we having a sleepover?" Catra sounded thrilled by the prospect. "I haven't had a sleepover in sooooooooooooooooo long."

"Uh...sure." Adora pulled the blanket up over her . "You just relax, okay? I'll be right back."

She was gone for all of fifty seconds, getting a glass of water and some aspirin. But Catra was sprawled out on the floor with Princess on her chest when Adora returned.

"Good puppy," Catra said cheerfully , patting Princess's head. "You have good taste in pets."

"Yours isn't too bad either," Adora said cautiously . "Melog's pretty great."

Catra laughed. "I knew you knew . Why didn't you say anything?"

"Because you didn't want me to know ," Adora said. "That was the whole point, wasn't it? You didn't want anyone to know your baggage."

"Hmmmn." Catra tilted her head. "I guess. That doesn't usually stop people, though. Everyone thinks they know best."

"I just wanted to do whatever helped you."

Catra smiled distantly, closing her eyes. "That's pretty neat. Thanks."

And then she was asleep. Adora watched her uncertainly, debating moving her. But she seemed comfortable, and Princess was already asleep. So Adora draped a blanket over them and leaned back against her bed, settling in for a long night.

This wasn't her bed.

This wasn't *any* bed, if Catra's protesting back had anything to say about it. The carpet was plush (though definitely not hers) and felt good against her skin, but a floor was a floor.

And the weight on her chest was definitely *not* her cat.

Melog tended to concentrate in one area ~~-u~~sually the middle of her chest ~~-a~~nd tucked his head under her chin. *This* was spread across her chest, the fur short and barely tickling her skin;a stark difference from Melog's fluff.

And her head *hurt*.

Catra groaned, forcing an eye open. Sunlight poured into the room through a window, immediately assaulting her sight and setting off a pounding a headache. She forced her eye shut again. Hungover. Fuck. How long had it been since *that* happened? And where *was* she?

"Catra?"

The voice was both familiar and not. Catra had only heard a couple times, but she would know it anywhere. She carefully opened her other eye, seeking out the speaker. She was leaning over Catra, blonde hair framing her slim face, blue eyes filled with worry.

Adora.

"Um." Catra's voice cracked. Her throat was dry, and everything hurt.

"Princess, budge," Adora said gently, shooing the dog off Catra's chest. Princess retreated with a small whimper, settling beside Catra and falling asleep again. "I've got some water for you. And aspirin. How're you feeling?"

Mortified. Catra had only planned on having a few drinks, really. She'd just felt cooped up in her apartment and had a rare itch to get

out.

And boy had she gotten out.

"Why am I on the floor?"

Adora laughed quietly, helping her sit up and handing her the water and pills. "I left to get you something to drink, and when I came back you were lying here playing with Princess. You seemed pretty comfortable, so I left it."

Catra took the aspirin and drained half the glass in one sip. She didn't feel as terrible as she *could*, so that was something. "Your phone's been going off," Adora said after a moment, pointing to the phone on the nightstand. "It fell out of your pocket."

"What time is it?"

"Almost noon."

Fuck. "It's brunch day," she mumbled, reaching for her phone. "My friends have been coming over to my place for it…"

And yup, thirteen missed calls from Scorpia, twelve total from Perfuma and Entrapta, twenty from Lyra, and twenty-three from Cyra. Catra curled her legs up to her chest, burying her face in her knees. She couldn't deal with this. She felt sick. The phone slipped from her hand, landing with a muffled *thump*.

"Can I go back to sleep?" she mumbled blearily. Adora pushed herself up, and a moment later Catra heard the tinny noise of a ringing phone on a line.

"*Adora*!" It was Perfuma's voice. Catra blinked, looking up. Adora had moved up to her bed, holding her own phone between them.

"Hey. Everything's okay."

It was so cryptic. Catra didnt understand. But Perfuma breathed a sigh of relief. "*Is she with you?*"

"Yeah. It's a long story."

"*I don't need to know. As long as she's okay*."

"Wait," Catra blurted out without thinking. "You did you"—

"*I figured it out on my own and promised Adora I wouldn't say anything*," Perfuma assured her. "*And no, I haven't told anyone else. I'll try to get Scorpia to back off. She called your moms, though*."

"Yeah, Ive got about forty missed calls from them." Catra scrubbed her eyes. "Sorry."

"*It's okay. Everyone will just be happy your safe. Do you need anything?*"

Catra looked between the phone and Adora, and groaned again. "A time machine?"

"*I'll let Entrapta know. She'll be thrilled*." Perfuma sounded vaguely amused. "*Let us know if there's anything else we can do to help*."

"I will. Um, thank you."

"*Of course*."

She hung up, and Adora set the phone aside. Catra watched her nervously. "I knew you knew," she said after a moment, ignoring the scratchy voice.

"You said that last night," Adora said with a teasing smile. "And Im sorry I didnt say anything, I just wanted to respect your wishes. You wanted anonymity."

Catra blinked a few times, staring at Adora in disbelief. "People dont usually listen to me," she finally said. "Everyone else knows what's

best."

Adora shrugged. "I don't."

That was refreshing. "You're weird," was what came out of Catra's mouth. Adora laughed.

"*You* rolled out of bed in the middle of the night to pick up a drunk stranger. Don't judge." Catra started to smile, but it turned into a yawn. "Do you want to lie down in an actual bed for a bit? I need to take Princess out for her walk."

That sounds amazing," Catra admitted. Adora offered a hand to help her up; Catra took it gratefully, and almost immediately collapsed into the bed. The pillow her face landed in was soft and smelled *good*. Like vanilla and fresh air and something unidentifiable that could only be called *Adora*.

"Sleep well," she heard Adora say before drifting back into unconsciousness.

She felt slightly better when she woke up again, yawning and rolling over. And there was Princess, watching her with bright, eager eyes. "Hey mutt," Catra mumbled, reaching out to scratch her ears. Princess's tail wagged eagerly, thumping against the nightstand. "Don't you have better things to do?"

"She loves attention," Adora said from the door. Catra lifted her head slightly to look at her. She was standing in the door, watching her with a small, amused smile.

The situation suddenly felt extremely surreal. Catra had gotten drunk and wound up on the doorstep of her anonymous friend, who'd let her sleep first on her floor, then in her bed. And sure, they hadn't *really* been anonymous for awhile now, but still, this was… humiliating. And she was so *exposed*. Adora was still a stranger. They'd never met in *person*. And now she had Catra in the most

vulnerable possible position. She could do *anything*, and Catra wouldn't be able to—

"Hey, hey."

Hands squeezed her shoulders, drawing her back to reality. Her breathing was ragged, eyes wide, vision glazed. She felt sick.

"It's okay," Adora assured her, running her hands up and down Catra's arms. "You're safe. Try and take a breath. Just one, okay? Focus on one breath."

Catra trembled, but nodded, focusing on Adora's hands, trying to follow the pattern of up and down, up and down. Her lungs slowly opened up, allowing her to take a shaking breath, then another, and another. Adora gave her a careful smile.

"Better?"

Catra nodded once, trying to still her shaking. "I'm...I'm sorry. You didn't ask for this. I should go—"

"It's okay," Adora said. "Take as long as you need. I'll give you a ride home when you're ready." Catra's phone buzzed on the nightstand. "But you might want to call your mothers."

Catra winced. "Oh. Right."

"I'm going to make something to eat. I think I've got everything for Bow's hangover meal." Adora squeezed Catra's arm gently. "Let me know if you need anything."

"Why are you being so nice?" Catra asked before Adora could leave. She paused, looking back at Catra, then shrugged.

"You're my friend."

She said it so simply, like it was obvious. But it left Catra stunned as she walked away. She missed the call from Cyra, but immediately

called back.

"*Catra?*"

"Hi, Mom," Catra said quietly.

"*Oh thank god. Lyra, she called!*"

Catra heard meowing in the background. "Are you at my apartment?"

There was a shuffling noise, presumably as Lyra grabbed the phone and put it on speaker. "*Are you okay?*"

"Yeah, I'm fine. I'm... I'm with a friend."

"*What friend?*" Stress made Cyra's voice crack. "*We've been talking to your friends all morning! Perfuma seems very nice, Scorpia should really bring her over to visit*"—

"*Cyra*," Lyra prompted her wife gently. "*Focus. Catra?*"

"It's um... someone I met through Perfuma." Not entirely a lie. "A friend of hers from school. We met at a housewarming party."

"*You never mentioned that*."

"I dont have to tell you guys *everything*."

Cyra made an aggravated noise. Lyra shushed her. "*Of course you don't*," she said. "*We were just worried about you*."

Catra's shoulders fell. She wasn't in the mood to fight. "I know. I'm sorry. If it helps, I think Mom knows one of her old roommates — purple hair, intern at Bright Moon General?"

"*Glimmer?*" Cyra's voice perked up noticeably. "*Is her old roommate a physical therapist here?*"

"Yeah."

"*I know her. Not well, but she's worked with a couple of my patients.*" Now Cyra sounded placated. "*She's a good person*."

"*As long as you're safe*," Lyra added. "*Do you need one of us to come get you?*"

"No, it's fine. I'm fine." Well, that was debatable. But Catra could deal with that on her own. "Could you feed Melog? I'm sure he's never eaten a day in his life."

"*We fed him when we got here*," Cyra said. "*Are you* sure *you can get home on your own?*"

"Yes, Mom, I'm sure. Really, really sure. I'll call if I need anything."

"*Okay*," Lyra said before Cyra could protest. "*Let us know when you get home*."

"I will." Catra scrubbed her eyes, sighing. "I love you."

"*We love you too. Talk later*."

"Mmhm."

Catra hung up and flopped back on the bed, staring at the ceiling. She could hear bacon sizzling in a pan, and smell it along with sausages and eggs. She wasn't sure if she was hungry or felt sick, but the aroma was too much to resist; she crawled out of bed, peeking out into the apartment.

Adora was at the stove, steadfastly ignoring Princess at her feet. The dog was surprisingly patient, just waiting for a piece of meat to slip. Catra smiled slightly despite herself.

"Throw the poor dog a bone, she's clearly starving."

Adora jumped, looking back at Catra. And she grinned. "Yeah, she's never been fed, you know. How're things with your moms?"

"Fine." Catra paused. "W ell, maybe not fine. Mom's kind of annoyed. But Mama's." Her voice drifted of f when she saw Adora struggling not to giggle. "What?"

"Nothing." Catra narrowed her eyes. "Just, ya know.it' s really cute you call her Mama."

Catra blushed. "It is *not*! Shut up!"

Adora stuck her tongue out. "What're you gonna do, *block me*?"

"Y ou're obnoxious."

"But you keep talking to me."

"I'm overlooking it for now because the food smells good."

Adora banished Princess to the couch, and they sat at the table together. It turned out Catra *was* hungry; she wolfed down half the bacon without a second thought. "Okay , this is good. You can stay."

"I'm honored," Adora said dryly , scooping up a bite of egg. "Are you this kind to everyone?"

"No. Y ou should feel *really* good about yourself."

They ate in silence for a bit; Catra could tell Adora was preparing herself to ask about what had happened, and she needed to figure out how to answer.

"Are..Are you okay?" W as what Adora finally settled for. Easy to lie or duck the question. She was giving Catra out.

"I'm." Catra stared at her food. Adora had given her space and let her pretend for months now. She deserved the truth. "No." She took a small bite of sausage. "No, I'm not."

"Do you want to talk about it?"

not really. Catra didn't immediately reject the idea however. She turned it around in her head, busying herself with food as she contemplated the answer. "It's complicated."

"I've got time."

She was so patient. So *good*. Catra didn't deserve it. "You know who I am, right? I mean, Perfuma told you all before we got to that housewarming party?"

Adora nodded. "She gave us some details. And I've seen the news about your old manager."

Catra shivered. "Yeah. That bitch."

"That can't *really* be legal, can it?"

"I'm not sure. It's not going to stop her, though. She'll do anything for a quick buck." Catra's voice was slightly bitter. She thought she'd earned that right.

"Does it bother you?"

"That she wants to profit off my trauma? Not really. I mean, she did that for years anyway. But there's... there's something she knows about me that I've never told the public, and it's not that I'm ashamed, I swear. But she... she made me keep it a secret for years, and I'm scared now."

"A secret so big it doesn't feel like yours anymore?" Adora said quietly. Catra almost smiled. She remembered that.

"Yeah. I want to tell people on *my* terms, not hers. And I don't want her telling anyone. But I... I don't know where to start. And I've been going in circles for days, and last night everything just got to be too much and I... I'm sorry." She muttered that last part, ears burning.

"It's okay," Adora said. "Do you... I mean, you can tell me, if you want. If you need someone to talk to."

Catra nodded, eyes still on her plate as she absently pushed food around. It shouldn't be hard – she'd already told Angella. She'd said the words for the first time in over a decade. And it hadn't killed her. And she knew Adora wouldn't be an ass about it – she was Perfuma's friend, after all. She took a deep breath, swallowing hard. Adora was silent, waiting for Catra to make her decision.

"I'm...I'm trans." Her stomach churned a little as she forced the words out, squeezing her eyes shut. "According to my moms, I informed them I was a girl when I was three. I kind of vaguely remember that. And being a girl has *always* felt right to me. Teachers used to deadname me before my moms legally changed my name, and it was the *worst*. Sometimes our gym classes were split into boys versus girls, and the teachers always put me with the boys, and I *hated* it. So there's never really been any question about it, you know? I know who I am.

"It never really came up in the early process of signing on with the record label, but Weaver eventually found out, and she was *so pissed*. Said I had *tricked her*. But I was *passing* enough that she decided not to drop me. I wasn't allowed to tell anyone about it, though. I never put much about myself on the internet, and anything that was there was scrubbed out of existence. Weaver said if I really wanted to be a girl, then I could be a girl, but I couldn't be anything else."

Silence fell. Catra dared to look up, meeting Adora's gaze. She looked...horrified. Furious. But not *at* Catra. The difference was important.

"That...That." Adora sputtered for a moment, trying to find the right word. "That *bitch*," was what she finally settled on. Catra smiled humorlessly.

"Yeah. My moms tried, ya know? They were really good. But we were all trapped under a contract and like ten different NDAs. And the label paid for hormones and surgeries and everything. I just wasn't allowed to tell anyone about it. I told myself it was fine, that

they weren't *stopping* me from being a girl, so there was nothing wrong with it, right?"

"You know that's wrong, right?" Adora asked slowly. "They were still forcing you to hide who you are."

"That's what Perfuma said," Catra murmured, poking at her eggs. "I guess. I'm still trying to deal with it all. But Weaver knows, and if she puts it in her book…"

"Then the entire world will know by the end of the week it's released," Adora finished. Catra nodded miserably. "Do you *want* to be out?"

"Kind of, yeah. When I was just posting YouTube covers, I used to imagine being like… I dunno, an idol for trans kids. Like, 'Hey look, we can be whatever we want.' I know it's stupid—"

"It's not," Adora argued.

"And Weaver ruined that, so it's not like it would do much *now*. But… I don't know, maybe I could help. I donate money to trans and LGBT organizations anonymously, since it's the only way I can really do anything, but if I could be out… if I could do *anything*… and it would just be nice to be myself. To not worry about someone else outing me before I can do it myself." She looked up, meeting Adora's gaze at last. "I'm just… tired of hiding things."

The double meaning in the words was obvious, and Adora picked up on it fast. "Then… don't? You still have control over it, even if you feel like you don't. Even if it's just a few small things."

"Yeah." Catra set her fork down, taking a deep breath. She held her hand out over the table, toward Adora. This was a good place to start, she supposed. "I'm Catra. Nice to meet you."

Adora tilted her for a moment before understanding lit up in her eyes, and she took Catra's hand. "Adora. Good to meet you too."

They shook.

Chapter End Notes

SO. I'm happy with where the story is ending now. I could get more into Catra coming out and her and Adora bonding more and everything, if people want, though I can't say when that chapter would come, which is why I'm marking this as complete for now. But is anyone interested in one more chapter?

The Truth, Finally

Chapter Summary

> Catra continues trying to navigate the minefield of her life. Adora is happy to help, even if it means stepping on a few along the way
>
> TW : Referenced/Past Homophobia and Transphobia

Chapter Notes

> HAPPY NEW YEAR! I wanted to have this done last night to end 2021, but I watched Encanto with my wife instead. I don't regret my life choices.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Do you.want to come up and meet Melog?"

Adora was staring up at the building they had stopped in front of. She'd figured Catra lived somewhere nice, but *this* was the kind of neighborhood she wouldn't be able to afford if she worked five lifetimes.

"What? Oh! Yes. Wait, are you sure?" She didn't want to invade. Catra laughed tiredly.

"Yes, I'm sure you can come up and meet my cat. Let me get the valet."

It wasn't until she'd already closed the door that her words registered with Adora. *Valet?*

Sure enough, she returned a moment later with a well-dressed man who greeted Adora politely and asked for her car keys. "Oh, um. I um. Sure?"

Catra was smiling as Adora stumbled out of the car. "You okay?"

"I've never seen a valet at an apartment building before." There was awe in her voice. "Do I have to pay them?"

"I pay and tip well, don't worry." Catra took Adora's hand, leading her into the building. She shot the doorman a smile as they passed, and he tipped his hat in return. They went to the elevators, and Catra hit the button before digging through her pockets. "Please tell me I'm not that stupid...ah."

She pulled out a card, and when they stepped into the elevator, she touched it against a pad over the floor buttons. "I like privacy," she said in response to the look Adora was giving her. "And all the levels of security are nice."

The elevator opened into a foyer with sleek, wooden floors, a coat rack off to one side, a small cat tree on the other. On the tree was a large, familiar gray cat, lying on the very top platform, tail swishing lazily. He raised his head, yawning, then meowed loudly, jumping down. He went straight to Adora, sniffing around her ankles.

"Melog." Catra sighed. "Be good."

He continued his investigation for nearly a minute before meowing again, headbutting Adora's shin, and then turning and heading up the stairs. "You've been Melog approved," Catra said dryly, kicking her shoes off. "Congratulations."

They followed the cat up the stairs. Adora stopped dead, mouth hanging open, when they reached the top. There was a door right across from them that led out onto a large patio. She could see a cat tree under the patio awning, and a set of patio furniture out in the light. To her right was a hallway that led to three different doors. To the left was a large living room, with a wall of windows looking out over the city. She counted three different cat trees in various areas, the biggest one next to a large, floofy looking couch. There was a TV

hanging on the wall, with a shelf below it covered in various electronics. The back wall was lined with several guitars and a piano.

"You play?" she asked without thinking. Catra chuckled.

"Yeah, I play. I didn't get into music just because of my good looks."

Right. That was a dumb question. "I played piano a bit when I was a kid. Couldn't sit still, but I was good."

"You'll have to play for me some time."

The words implied that Adora was welcome to come *back*. Her heart quickened slightly at the idea. "Want anything to drink? I'm sure my moms stocked my fridge while I was gone."

"Oh, sure. Water, please?"

Catra disappeared into what must have been the kitchen. Melog had climbed up the largest tree and settled in again, tail wrapping around himself. Adora walked toward him, stepping around the frankly absurd amount of cat toys (Catra hadn't been kidding when she said Melog only accepted the best), and approached slowly. The shelf Melog had settled on was just at her head level.

"Hello," she cooed quietly. "Can I pet you?"

Melog *mrowled*, ears twitching. Adora took a chance, lightly scritching his scalp. That, it seemed, was acceptable; he lifted his head to push into her touch. She laughed.

"Shameless," Catra said as she walked out, handing Adora a water bottle. Adora reluctantly stopped petting Melog to take the bottle.

"Leave him alone, he's cute."

"I meant you."

Adora squawked indignantly, and Catra laughed. She flopped onto the couch, letting her head fall back to look at the ceiling. Adora hesitated before joining her.

"Are... Are you okay?"

Catra sighed heavily, closing her eyes. "I don't know. Maybe. No. I'm scared."

Adora leaned back with her, shifting closer to nudge her shoulder against Catra's. "I know you liked what we had going on, and I'm still willing to be your weird phone friend you text about food, but... can I ask if you're okay now?"

"Do I really have a choice?"

"Yes." Catra lifted her head to look at Adora, surprised. "You have enough people to ask if you're okay. If you really don't want another one, then just... tell me what you need me to be."

Catra stared at her for a minute, clearly bewildered, and maybe a little close to crying. Someone was *actually* giving her a choice. This was such a small, stupid thing, but... it was a choice.

"I guess it's all right," she finally said, letting out a long breath. "Just don't like, ask every five minutes or anything. I might think you like me or something."

Adora scoffed. "Trust me, I don't want to contribute to your ego like that."

"*What – Entrapta did you just shoot me?! I thought we were on the same team!*"

"*I* told you *the teams are randomized – you ended up on the other team this time.*"

"*Catra hasn't shot me!"*

"*I don't think Catra's playing anymore. She hasn't moved from spawn."*

"What?" Catra blinked herself out of her haze, looking at her TV screen to see little characters moving all around her, firing various versions of souped-up paintball guns at each other. "*Shit*. I didn't realize the round started."

"*It's okay! Scorpia's spent most of the time trying to hit her own teammates and not taking any ground, so the teams have basically been even*."

Catra looked at the laptop. Entrapta and Scorpia were sitting in a video call with her while they played a game together, something they hadn't done in a *long* time. Scorpia looked downright horrified. Entrapta was having the time of her life.

"*And we win!*" she cheered as the end screen popped up.

"*Can I be on your team this time?*"

"*It's* random*, I can't make it be different*."

Luckily they were put on the same team for the next round. "*So*," Scorpia started slowly as the game began. "*What were you thinking about?*"

"Nothing." Catra gave the game more attention than it really deserved, charging up her sniper rifle to take out someone on the other team.

"*Were you thinking about your anonymous phone friend?*" Entrapta asked. "*You always have a certain look on your face when you think about her, I've been documenting it*"–

"No! And *why* have you been documenting it?"

"*Social science is still science!*"

Catra sighed deeply, rolling her eyes. "If I tell you guys something, are you going to freak out?"

"*Do you know who it is?!*" That was the only thing in the world that could tear Entrapta's attention away from the game.

"Entrapta, focus! We're the only ones on this team who have any fucking clue what we're doing." Scorpia didn't argue that fact. "And… yes."

"*Really?!*" Entrapta and Scorpia screeched at the same time. The noise was jarring enough that Catra dropped her controller, giving someone an opportunity to take her out. God damn it.

"Okay, now I'm not telling you."

"*You have to!*" Scorpia protested. "*We need to make sure she's good enough for you!*"

"She's—ugh." Catra groaned, launching her little character back into the chaos. "*Fine*. It's one of Perfuma's friends. Adora."

"*Adora?*" Entrapta was scrolling through something on her tablet. "*Blonde hair, blue eyes, used to live with Bow and his fiancee?*"

Bow was the *only* person Entrapta remembered from the housewarming party. Which wasn't surprising, honestly. He was the only one who spoke her language. "Yeah."

"*Adora's nice,*" Scorpia said slowly. "*How long have you known it was her?*"

"Since the housewarming party. I'm not the one who was drunk off my ass, remember? I knew her face. And she kind of remembered me. But we didn't really…confirm it or anything until a couple weeks ago."

"*And does she know… everything?*"

"Not every gruesome detail, but nobody knows those." Catra took a moment to take out someone on the other team. "Not until Weaver's fucking book comes out at least."

"*Oh, I was going to talk to you about that,*" Entrapta spoke up. "*I've been looking into the publishing company that bought her manuscript, and it has* terrible *online security*—"

"Entrapta, *no*."

"*Don't rule it out*," Scorpia said.

"I don't even want to know what you would *do*—"

"*Oh, there's a ton of stuff I could do once I was in their system. Delete the manuscript and her contract, mess up their entire accounting department, put every book currently in the process of being published on a permanent hold*—"

"I said I don't want to know!"

"*And* I'm *saying the possibilities are endless*!"

The round ended with their team winning, *barely*. Between Scorpia being Scorpia and Entrapta getting distracted, it had been close. The next round had Catra on a different team. "*But Adora knows… things?*" Scorpia pushed after a second, completely unsubtle. Catra rolled her eyes.

"She knows I'm trans, yes."

"*Oh good*." Scorpia sighed. "*I mean, I didn't think she'd be a jerk about it since Perfuma and Bow are too, but still. I can't hack into an entire company for you, but I can throw someone in front of a car if they're mean!*"

"You said that *way* too cheerfully. You can't even kill me in a glorified paintball gun game."

"*That's different, you're my best friend!*"

"You're *on the other team*. I just shot you!"

"*And I forgive you for that*."

"I'm not sorry."

"*Don't worry Scorpia!*" Entrapta piped up. "*I'll get revenge for you!*"

And *this* was why they couldn't be allowed on different teams.

"Why are Dr. Driluth and her wife staring at you?"

Adora had been doing her best to ignore it, but of course Glimmer had to call attention to it as soon as she sat down. Catra must have told them *something* about her. Were they planning an ambush?

"Okay, here's the thing." Adora took a deep breath. "Remember the night before you moved out when we were celebrating Spinnerella's and Netossa's engagement and I got *really* drunk and tried to call you but I swapped the last two digits in your number and called some stranger? It um...it was Catra."

Glimmer blinked a few times, slowly processing the information. "You drunk-dialed a former celebrity at two in the morning?"

"Yeah. And she actually came to pick me up." Glimmer's mouth fell open. "I know, right? Who does that? I mean, she does, obviously. And I called her the next day after you changed your number in my phone, to apologize, ya know? I kind of recognized her voice from the night before, but I didn't know she was famous or anything, and she never told me her name. And we um...we've been talking ever since."

"*What*? Seriously?" Glimmer asked in disbelief. "Is *she* your secret girlfriend?"

Well, if Dr. Driluth and her wife *hadn't* been openly staring at Adora, they certainly were now. "I don't have a girlfriend!" Adora hissed, resisting the urge to fall over and hope the ground swallowed her whole.

"But you *have* been talking to someone, and you always get that stupid little smile—"

"It's not *like that*!" Adora was scrambling to get her phone out of her pocket and pull up her text thread with Catra.

Princess 👑

Your mothers are going to kill me, please help

Catra 👊🏻⬛

Why would they do that?

Princess 👑

I don't know! I was just sitting here eating my lunch when Dr. Driluth showed up with her wife and they've both been staring at me

And I just told Glimmer about you and she asked if you're my girlfriend LOL YOU DUMB

Catra 👊🏻⬛

wtf

Dr. Driluth's phone rang a few seconds later. She quickly answered, and Adora put her phone away. Glimmer was trying not to laugh.

"Did you just text her?"

"I'm *trying* to make sure her mothers don't murder me! It's kind of a weird situation, okay?"

Glimmer softened up a little. "Is... everything okay? I mean, clearly something happened if her moms are being like this."

"Yeah. Her old manager—"

"The bitch with the book?"

"That one, yes. She's been really stressed out over it, and she got drunk Saturday night and ended up at my place, and her friends were freaking out when they couldn't get ahold of her the next morning, and it turned into a huge thing—"

"And I'm sure our daughter would appreciate if you didn't spread it around."

Adora cringed, looking at Catra's mothers. The intimidating stares only lasted about a second before a voice on Dr. Driluth's phone snapped, "*Mom! Leave her* alone. *This is bullying*."

Mrs. Driluth plucked the phone from her wife's hand and turned away, saying, "She's just looking out for you – I don't know – I think it's called having seniority—"

"Um... I should get back to work," Adora muttered, shoveling down the last of her lunch and bolting. She was just putting her lunchbox down in her office when her phone went off again.

Catra 👍🏻⬛

Sorry about them. They care too much sometimes

They were SUPPOSED to apologize to you

Princess 👑

It's fine, I'm sure it sounded like I was just gossiping or something

Catra 

You're allowed to talk about the drunk weirdo who showed up at your apartment at two in the morning

God knows I've gotten a ton of mileage out of the one who CAME to ME at two in the morning

Princess 

Okay, I feel a little less bad now

Catra glared at the blinking cursor.

She knew what she needed to say – it was easy , really – but the words wouldn't just appear on the page like she wanted them to.

The elevator dinging was a welcome distraction.

"Were you seriously going to go after her *at work?* Aren't you her boss or something?"

"I don't work directly with the physical therapists," Cyra called back stiffly.

"And we weren't going to *go after her*," Lyra added. "We just wanted to get to know her."

"At *work*?"

"Maybe it wasn't the best approach."

Catra shoved her laptop away, standing, and going to meet her mothers at the top of the stairs. "Seriously , I thought you were *happy* I was making new friends."

"We *are.*" Lyra gathered her in a quick hug. "We just also worry."

"Adora didn't even know who I was for like two months. And she's… she's been good. It's fine."

"We're sorry," Cyra said reluctantly. Catra knew how hard it was for her to admit she was wrong.

"It's fine, just don't threaten her at work."

Cyra rolled her eyes, pulling Catra into a tight hug as well. "We weren't *threatening* her."

"She was convinced you were going to kill her."

"It wasn't that bad!"

Lyra went to start dinner while Cyra and Catra settled on the couch. Cyra tilted her head at the laptop. "Writing something?"

"Trying." Catra ran a hand through her hair, huffing in frustration. "I don't know what to say."

She'd testified in court about the abuse the label and her manager had put her through. But that had been different. She'd felt disconnected. They overworked her. They berated her. They definitely broke several child labor laws. But it hadn't been *personal*. They had worked her into the ground and she had hated it, but it had just been business. Forcing her backward into a closet for a decade and some change? That had taken a deep mental toll on her. And she didn't know how to work through it.

Cyra tugged Catra close, wrapping a blanket around her. "I know you don't want to go to court again—"

"It's just going to be the same result," Catra said tonelessly. "I'll have to say it in court, and it'll be all over Twitter by the end of the day, or she'll put it in her book. The only difference is that one way gets her money. Even this doesn't get to be my choice."

Cyra hugged Catra a little tighter. She hated this so much. She hadn't been able to protect her then, and she couldn't protect her now, and she hated it. Maybe she could help her focus on something else, though.

"So...Adora."

"Do *not*," Catra groaned.

"I'm just saying! She seems very nice. I know she's good at her job."

"And she's already properly afraid of you. Prime girlfriend material, right?"

"I wouldn't say *that*." Cyra put on a look of mock shock. "I don't want anyone to be *afraid* of me."

"Sure, Mom. Sure."

"And now I don't think I can ever go back to work."

Bow smiled at Adora, who had her head in his lap. "I *think* you're being overdramatic." Then he looked at Glimmer to mouth, *Right?* She shrugged back. Dr. Driluth *was* a force of nature sometimes. "But wow that is definitely a lot."

Princess came over to nudge at Adora's hand, which was dangling off the edge of the couch. "I was just trying to help. I didn't think it would cause all of...this."

"Even if you had, you can't say you would have just put her back in an Uber and gone to sleep."

"No," Adora admitted, petting Princess. "She's been so unhappy. And now I can actually *talk* to her about it, and that should be good right? But I don't know what to say. And her mothers probably want to kill me."

I *doubt* they want to kill you.”Again, Bow looked at Glimmer . And again, Glimmer shrugged. She really could not, in conscience, say that Dr. Driluth felt zero ill-will toward Adora. She seemed like someone who would be a very protective parent. And Glimmer knew absolutely nothing about her wife.

None of them had tried to look Catra up after meeting her. Sure, the details were public, but they didn't have to know . She'd been perfectly nice, if not a little quiet and sarcastic, and that was all they needed. But it was so hard not to now. Adora would respect Catra's privacy, though. Even if it killed her.

(Maybe that was a little dramatic.)

Catra 🫵🏻⬛

So don't freak out

Princess 👑

Not a great way to start a conversation, but okay

Adora did her best to sound unbothered, but that really was a *terrible* way to say good morning to someone. And what was Catra even doing awake? She usually slept until noon unless her mothers were around.

Catra 🫵🏻⬛

You have absolutely no obligation to say yes

Princess 👑

Say yes to what?

Catra hadn't replied by the time Adora's first patient came in. She did her best to put it out of her mind and focus. It was probably nothing.

There was a message waiting for Adora when she finally took her break for lunch.

Catra 👍🏿

My moms have decided they're too out of the loop in my life

And took it upon themselves to invite Scorpia and Entrapta over for dinner on Sunday

Perfuma is coming too because they haven't met her

They WOULD have invited you if they had your phone number , but I refused to give it to them

Hopefully you see these texts before my mom gets her hands on you

Anyway, I told them I'd invite you, and they want a screenshot of the message and your reply as proof, so

Do you want to go to my moms' for dinner this weekend?

Adora was suddenly *very* glad she'd decided to eat lunch in her office. It was no big *deal* that Catra's mothers wanted to meet her – they obviously cared a lot about their daughter and wanted to make sure she had good people in her life. And other people were going to be there. It wasnt weird or anything. Right?

Princess 👑

You think I'm going to say no to free food?

Catra 👍🏿

Mama IS one of the best cooks in the city

Princess 👑

I still think it's adorable that you call her Mama

Catra 

Shut up

"You look so cute in a dress!" Perfuma cooed as she examined the wall of photos documenting Catra's life. And boy was Catra *already* regretting saying okay to this whole stupid dinner.

"Is that our second grade class picture?" Scorpia asked, looking over our girlfriend's shoulder. "Our moms color coordinated us, it was the best class picture ever."

"Alas, it was the only year in her entire life that she willingly wore a dress," Lyra called from the kitchen. "We knew it wouldn't last, so we got as many pictures as we could. Cyra, do you know where the photo album is for that Christmas?"

"*No!*" Catra said loudly, shooting up from the couch. "We are *not* doing picture time!"

"She's right," Cyra agreed. Catra stupidly thought she had an ally. "We should wait for Adora to get here."

"We're not doing picture time when Adora gets here!" Catra threw her hands up in disgust. "Will *someone* in this room help me?"

"You probably shouldn't show Adora the pictures tonight," Entrapta piped up. "You'll want to save them for future dinners when Adora attends as Catra's girlfriend."

Catra could *feel* the vein in her forehead twitching. The doorbell blessedly saved her from any more argument. "No pictures," she informed Cyra sternly before running to get the door. She just needed her mothers and friends to behave for a couple hours. *One* meal. They could be normal for *one meal*, couldn't they?

Adora was waiting on the doorstep, rocking nervously on her heels. She smiled when Catra let her in. "Hey . Not too late, am I?"

"Mama' s still cooking, you've got at least an hour to spare." Which meant an hour with nothing to do but *talk* to the others. Catra wished she could've been a little later . "Come on, the weirdos are waiting."

"Hi Adora!" Perfuma swooped in to hug her . "How are you?"

"I'm good." Adora squeezed her once before pulling away to look at Catra's mother. Cyra Driluth was about as tall as her daughter, and didn't look overly threatening in her mom jeans and knitted sweater and slippers. And yet Adora shifted nervously, moving her weight from foot to foot.

"Hello, Dr . Driluth."

Cyra smiled. "W e're not at work, dear . You can call me Cyra."

That was probably not going to happen, but Adora still nodded. "That' s what happens when you scare her, isn't it?" Catra grumbled, shooting Cyra a half-hearted glare.

"W e weren't *trying* to scare her"—

"Cyra!" L yra called from the kitchen. "Can you come get the snacks? And does Adora want a drink?"

"Um, just water , please."

"Oh, right." Catra gave Adora an appraising look. "My mom made cookies. There are *chocolate chips* in them. That' s not going to ruin your entire life, will it?"

"No ." Adora scof fed, giving Catra a light shove. "Will you get over your weird hang up about my food habits?"

"T ell me about kale, again."

Cyra returned with the cookies and a water bottle, and everyone settled in. Adora was trying to look discreet as she eyed the picture wall with Perfuma. She wasn't very good at it.

"Is that – are you an *elf*?" she asked during a lull in conversation, squinting at one of the photos. Catra rolled her eyes.

"Yeah, it was the fourth grade Christmas play. Exclusive one-night only event because Entrapta lit something on fire backstage."

"But not before Catra did her solo about helping Santa feel better and saving Christmas," Cyra said fondly .

"Is that the year the teacher dressed me up as a tree?" Scorpia asked with a small pout.

"Yes, but in her defense everyone was still talking about you accidentally taking down the props while you were trying to dance in the play the year before."

"I see you in the background!" Perfuma said. "You're such a cute little tree."

Scorpia blushed. "The school gave up on Christmas plays after that year," Catra said. "Or at least until the three of us left. Hopefully they learned their lesson and stopped making it *mandatory* for everyone to participate, because that was really the problem."

"I *did* tell them I wasn't interested in doing backstage tech work," Entrapta pointed out.

"Taking apart the switchboard for the lights was *not* the answer to that problem."

"So yes, they've always been like this," Cyra told Adora with a small wink. "The pictures seemed to taper out at some point in middle school – probably after Catra had signed on with the label, Adora realized. There hadn't been time for school plays and silly friend

things once she was a musical sensation. Which was too bad. She looked so *happy* in all the photos.

"Mooooooooooooooom, is the food almost ready?"

"Twenty more minutes!" Lyra called back, sounding amused. Catra groaned dramatically.

"Are there any more cookies?"

"No, you'll ruin your appetite."

"*Mean*."

It was a side of Catra that Adora didn't really *know*. She was comfortable, bickering with her moms and lightly teasing her friends. They all knew exactly what topics to avoid, and Catra knew she didn't have to worry.

She has a really nice smile.

Adora shook that thought off quickly. *No*. Catra needed a *friend*, not some weirdo with a crush.

Dinner was amazing. The food was great, and Lyra and Cyra took great joy in regaling Adora and Perfuma with stories from Catra's (and Entrapta's and Scorpia's) childhood. It probably wasn't something they got to talk about often.

"You should grow your hair out again," Lyra said as she walked by Catra to put some dishes in the sink. Apparently she and Scorpia had tried to give each other haircuts when they were six. Cyra promised the pictures were great, and she would find them for next time.

(*Next time?*)

"I *am*, it just takes forever to grow," Catra grumbled. "We don't all have Entrapta's freaky hair."

"I've just never cut it," Entrapta said, shrugging.

"Really?" Adora asked. "Glimmer always tells me I have to cut mine at least a *little* to take care of split ends and stuff."

Entrapta frowned, taking one of her pigtails and examining it critically. "Oh. I guess I've done *that*. One of Scorpia's moms is a professional hair stylist, she helped me with most of that stuff when we were kids."

"Speaking of, they want to know when you're going to be in Half Moon again," Scorpia said. "Perfuma and I are going at the end of the month if you want to join. You too, Catra."

"I think I need like a two-month break from all parents after tonight."

"Fair enough. There's always Christmas. Oh, Adora can come too!"

Catra raised an eyebrow, and Scorpia immediately realized she'd put her foot in her mouth. "I doubt Adora wants to drive three hours to Half Moon just to meet your moms."

"I-right I just meant...you know how my moms are, they always want to meet people we uh...we're..."

"Scorpia." Lyra to the rescue. "Can you help me get something off the top shelf?"

"Yes ma'am!" Scorpia's voice cracked as she shot out of her seat and hurried into the kitchen. Adora looked at Catra, confused.

"What was that about?"

"Nothing," Catra said quickly. "Absolutely nothing. Don't worry about it."

Lyra and Scorpia returned with cake, and Adora had *thought* she was full until she saw it. "When was the last time you had cake?"

Catra teased as she cut a slice and put it on Adora's plate.

"Glimmer 's birthday party. I *do* eat more than celery and peanut butter, you know."

"I absolutely do *not* believe you."

It was, all and all, a nice night. Cyra and Lyra were both on their best behavior, and truly enjoyed meeting Perfuma and Adora.

"What do you think?" L yra asked once everyone had left. Cyra was lying on the couch, eyes closed.

"A month, max."

"Really? Y ou know what Catra's like. And Adora doesn't seem overly pushy."

"She' s different around Adora. I *know* you noticed."

"There had definitely been an easy casualness between the two. Small touches, sitting just a *little* too close to each other, the bickering that was too light to be mean-spirited…

"T wo months," Cyra allowed. "Or I let you trade in our old car . I know you've been eyeing those electric ones."

Lyra smiled, sitting and leaning in to kiss her wife's forehead. "Like I haven't been looking into trading that thing in for months now ."

"My ego will handle it better if you do it because you win a bet."

There are a lot of things

Delete.

I was only thirteen when I signed on to the label

Delete.

Words are fucking hard, I'm transgender , okay?

Catra seriously considered just posting that for a moment before she deleted the whole thing and threw her phone aside. She was lying on her couch, staring at the ceiling, while Melog slept on her chest.

"Maybe I don't have to do this," she murmured after a moment. Did it *really* matter if Weaver outed her? Was she thinking too hard about this?

"What do you think, buddy?"

Melog purred in his sleep. Very useful. Catra sighed, giving his ears a small scratch. It wasn't his fault he was a cat and couldn't actually provide insight into the situation. But it would've been nice to have an impartial third party to bounce ideas off of.

Maybe I should consider going back to therapy.

She picked up her phone again, then set it aside when she realized she didn't want to talk to anyone. Then she picked it up again. She wanted to do *something*. She was restless, and she hated it. Her foot was bouncing against the arm of the couch, fingers twitching. Finally she sat up, dislodging Melog. He fell with an undignified squawk, recovering himself to land on his feet and jump onto his tree. Catra ignored the look he gave her as she crossed the room, picking up the acoustic guitar. She stared at it for a long moment, then looked up at Melog.

"What do you think?"

It had *months* since the last time she had picked up any instrument with the intention of playing. Her piano and guitar collection were just collecting dust. Music was another thing Weaver and the label had taken from her.

When are you going to start taking things back?

She sat with the guitar, strumming it mindlessly. Her fingers shook just a little, but the longer she played, the better she felt. She didn't like much of her own music, and she didn't want to play any of that anyway. Her musical knowledge had at one time been rather extensive, considering she'd been learning and making her own covers. But it'd been so long, she was surprised anything came back to her.

"*Well I couldn't tell you why she felt that way, she felt it every day…*"

It was almost effortless, recalling the chords, placing her fingers in the right places. "*And I couldn't help her, I just watched her make the same mistakes again…*"

It felt *good*. Like a knot was loosening in her chest. Music had been therapeutic to her at one time. She had forgotten that feeling. Everything had become about work and just getting the next album out, getting through the next concert. It stopped being *fun*.

She hummed before switching to another song.

"*My lover's got humor, she's a giggle at a funeral…*"

And she just kept going. She switched between songs, throwing in a few of her own here and there, but mostly sticking to covers. She even started smiling as she sang, finally remembering *why* she enjoyed it so much.

Melog dozed on his tree, completely unaware of the miracle unfolding not ten feet away from him.

Catra 

This is your daily reminder to have one bite of chocolate

Princess 👑

Seriously?

Catra 😾⬛

Yes, I'm very serious about chocolate

"Someone's talking to her girlfriend," Glimmer sang, smiling deviously at Adora. "Come on, can't we get your attention for five minutes?"

"Be nice, Glimmer," Bow chided his fiancee.

"She's not my girlfriend," Adora muttered, putting her phone away. Brunch was Best Friend Squad time. But she hated making Catra wait. Even if it was for something stupid like the Daily Chocolate Reminder.

"You met her parents. You're definitely dating."

"Her parents invited me over with her *other friends*. It was a *friend* thing."

"All right," Bow said slowly. "But you know it's *okay* if you have feelings, right?"

Adora rolled a grape between her fingers before popping it into her mouth. "I guess," she muttered. "But she doesn't need that."

"Have you *asked* her what she needs, or are you just assuming?" Adora didn't answer. Bow nodded. "Kinda what I thought. Look, I know she has some stuff. But you're *allowed* to have feelings."

"I know."

"And you never know what's going on in her head until you ask," Glimmer added. "Even if the timing isn't right, you can be honest with

each other.”

Adora hated it when her friends made this much sense. Her phone buzzed again, distracting her, and she gratefully pulled it out. There was a picture of chocolate-covered strawberries attached to the most recent message.

Catra 👍🏽

I’ve been told to inform you that Super Pal Trio brunches > Best Friend Squad brunches

I’m not sure how we’re still the Super Pal Trio since Perfuma always comes now

But Scorpia won’t answer that question

Princess 👑

I’ll give you $10 to eat one strawberry NOT covered in chocolate

---

The cursor blinked at Catra, mocking her. She stared at it. It continued to blink. She switched to her texts.

Catra 👍🏽

Wanna come over?

Princess 👑

I’m a little insulted you assume I don’t already have plans or something

Catra 👍🏽

Just pull up in front of the building, I’ll let the valet know you’re coming. Text me when you’re here so I can send the elevator down

Maybe she'd get a card for Adora. Her moms, Scorpia, and Entrapta all had their own, although Entrapta's was mostly to stop her from trying to hack the elevator's security system. Adora would probably need one as well if she was going to be a more permanent part of Catra's life.

(Was she going to be? Catra *wanted* her to be).

Adora texted her when she got there, and Catra hit the button on the outside panel to send elevator down and let Adora up.

"Do you have to do that for everyone?" she asked in lieu of greeting as she stepped out.

"The building security will make copies of the key card if I ask nice and pay. Entrapta said once she could probably copy it with a blank credit card, but I'm not sure how *legal* that is since I'm not sure who owns the elevator – like, I bought the penthouse, but the elevator might still technically be the building's property?" Catra shrugged. "Either way , trying to stop her from tampering with things is always in everyone's best interest. She'd probably turn the elevator sentient and evil."

Melog came trotting down the stairs to inspect the new arrival, then meowed loudly and wound himself through Adora's legs before going back upt the stairs. "Y ou officially have permission to enter."

"So permission has to come from Melog?"

"Of course. I just pay for things. This is really *his* place."

Adora had visited a couple times by this point, and immediately spotted something out of place when she stepped foot in the living room. "Have you been playing your guitar?"

"Y eah, a little." Catra ducked into the kitchen to get a couple water bottles. "Nothing too extreme, just messing around with old songs I did covers for. Pretty sure all those videos are gone now."

She couldn't keep the sadness out of her voice. She wanted those videos back. Wanted those memories back. Wanted her lanky, awkward, thirteen-year-old self fussing with the camera as she introduced herself and explained the song she had chosen for the week and why. Wanted the two or three vlogs she had done about being trans, and all the frustrations that came with it. She'd done an hour rant about gym class once, and had gotten a lot of support and positivity in return. It had made her feel so *good*. Until it had been locked away with everything else in the contracts.

"Do you need company , or something specific?" Adora asked, and tension immediately drained from Catra's shoulders. This was why she had texted Adora. Her moms or Scorpia would've come in a heartbeat, she was sure, but they would have been immediately proactive with trying to cheer Catra up. And that was great, Catra loved them for it...but sometimes she needed an option.

"Company . Please."

They settled on the couch together , putting on a random Netflix show in the background while they talked, and Catra fiddled with her guitar. She'd been neglecting the poor thing,

"I know you said company ," Adora said during a pause in their inane conversation about peanut butter cups versus milky ways. "But can I still ask if you're okay? I saw the um"…

"The news?" Catra laughed bitterly . It wasn't *really* news —a release date had been announced for Weaver's book. It was about two months away. "Y eah, I'm fine. Kind of."

"Still not sure how to tell people?"

"No." Catra slumped against the couch, setting the guitar aside. "And now I have a deadline, assuming something doesn't get leaked early , and I...I'm so *angry* at her for taking this away from me. Coming out is supposed to be *my* choice."

Adora tugged Catra close, pulling her into a gentle hug. Catra burrowed her into her. Her arms felt so good. So *safe*. "I know it's not the same at *all*, but I was outed before I actually knew I was gay."

Catra snorted. "How the hell?"

"Guy in my Algebra class asked me out in tenth grade. I wasn't interested in him, and I said no, and he decided to tell everyone that I said no because I was, in his words 'a giant dyke.'" Adora rolled her eyes. "I *probably* should have already known that. I mean, I played football."

"You *definitely* should have already known that."

"But honestly, it just never occurred to me, and suddenly every single kid in my grade was talking about how I was gay and how it was *so obvious*, and it sucked because I felt like something had been taken away from me. I never got the chance to really, I dunno, explore my own sexuality. It was confusing then, and looking back on it, it makes me mad. Like I said, I know it's *nothing* like what you're dealing with—"

"It's not completely dissimilar either," Catra said quietly. "Teenagers are the fucking worst."

"Hey, we were teenagers once."

"And as the world's leading expert on myself, I can confidently say that I was, in fact, the Fucking Worst." She let Adora give her one more squeeze before sitting up. "Why was it so much easier to tell the world I'm gay after I got out of the label?"

"I mean, I'm not an expert, but I can only assume that homophobic corporation made me hide my sexuality is simpler than trying to figure out how to explain that they made you hide being trans while still allowing you to present as a girl."

Catra ruffled her hair, sighing. "Yeah. When Weaver said I was *passing enough*... I felt kind of sick, to be honest. I was a stupid kid, and I didn't know any better, and being *passing* should be good, right? It means no one will bother me. But it was like... like cutting off my arm or something. It was an important part of me. About a year before things went to hell, some studio did a documentary on young artists, and they interviewed me for it, and I had to talk about my childhood. Everyone loves a good struggling kid turned superstar story, right? But all of my major struggles were centered around being trans – teachers deadnaming me, putting me with boys during the gym class, making me change in the boys' locker room, stuff like that. And I couldn't talk about *any* of it.

"I think they ended up cutting me out because I had to sanitize the story so much that it wasn't *interesting*. And don't get me wrong, the tragic trans narrative is played to death, but... imagine being a trans kid and seeing someone you look up to talk about going through the exact same things *you've* gone through. If it had helped even *one* person, it would have been worth it."

Adora took her hand, squeezing it gently. "Maybe you could tell the story now?" she asked quietly. Catra looked up, blinking a few times. "I know it's a few years late, but... there's probably still some kid out there who needs to hear it."

Catra stared at her, hazy bits of an idea pulling themselves together in her mind. "Will you... help me with it?"

"Absolutely," Adora said without hesitation. Something warm swelled in Catra's chest. What had she done to deserve this amazing person in her life?

Two weeks later, a new YouTube channel was made, with one video immediately uploaded, titled *Not Hiding Anymore*. It was fifteen minutes and twenty-three seconds long.

Catra was sitting on her couch, with Melog wandering in and out of the shot, because there had been no way to easily contain him, and in the end, she'd decided to just let it be. This wasn't meant to be professional. It was meant to be honest.

"Hi, everyone." She waved, a bit awkwardly, and smiled. "At this point, most of you probably know me as the person who blew the lid off Prime Records rampant artist abuse. I kind of hope some people remember that I had a music career too, I was proud of it at one point. For the ten or so people who have managed to avoid all pop culture in the last three years, I'm Catra, and I *really* want to know how you managed that."

A low tune played in the back of the video, sometimes an acoustic guitar, sometimes and electric, sometimes, a piano. It shifted and changed as the video went on.

"The details are public, so I'm not going to spend much time on it, because it isn't what I want to talk about, but basically—Prime Records was signing young artists into completely terrible contracts that let them micromanage every single aspect of a person's life and work them into the ground. I was lucky. I was *really* lucky, and had two moms who were willing to bankrupt themselves to get me out. It didn't go that far, don't worry.

"And when I say micromanage, I mean they had a *lot* of queer artists, including myself, that they forced into the closet because they didn't think queer would *sell*. Which tells you exactly how much they know about their demographic, but I digress. I came out as a lesbian basically the minute I was out from under the contract. But that… that wasn't the only thing they forced me to hide."

Melog jumped into her lap, nudging her hand. Catra rolled her eyes, giving him scritches. "This is Melog, just accept that he's part of the video."

She focused on scratching his ears for a few seconds before sighing and looking back at the camera. "I was thirteen when Prime Records

found my original YouTube channel. All they saw was the music and the views, and they wanted to make me their next money-making puppet. We were halfway through the whole signing process when my manager, Sharon Weaver, found a couple other videos I'd posted ~~-no~~thing special, just a stupid thirteen year old complaining about stupid thirteen-year-old things."

She paused, taking a deep breath. "They were about being transgender. According to my moms, I was three when I very firmly informed them I was a girl, and wouldn't hear anything against it. And sure, I was three, it could've just been a phase, but they let me be what felt right to me and were always supportive. It never really occurred to them or to me that it was something we needed to *disclose* to Prime Records.

"But Weaver found a video I'd posted about a shitty gym teacher trying to force me into the boy's locker room, and she was furious. She went on this whole rant about how we had *tricked* the company and how much time they had already wasted on me. My moms tried to back out after that, but we'd already signed a bunch of contracts, and Weaver said we could work with it, that I was *passing enough* that no one would be able to tell the difference. "The label even agreed to pay for hormones and whatever medical procedures I'd need. But if I *wanted to be a girl*, then I had to be a girl. I wasn't allowed to talk about being trans."

Melog hopped off Catra's lap, onto the back of the couch. "And that probably sounds like a good deal, right? I thought it was, at first. I could just be a girl, and no one would bother me about stupid gender things like what *bathroom* I was allowed to use. It felt like I could just be *me*. It took me so long to realize how tiring it was to hide an entire part of myself. I didn't know how much being trans was part of my identity until I couldn't talk about it anymore. I didn't know how miserable it was making me until I was."…

Her voice drifted off, and she shook her head. "And it's still a part of myself that I'm hiding, because I spent so long thinking that I had it easy ~~-so~~ what if I couldn't talk about being trans? They let me be a

girl, and that was all that mattered. It was all I *wanted*. I don't have any right to complain *now*. And, honestly, I probably would have kept hiding it, if Weaver hadn't decided to publish an entire book about working with Prime Records. I have no idea what's in it. I wasn't consulted about what parts of *my life* she was allowed to write about. But nothing is really *too low* for her, and I wouldn't put it passed her to try and spin some narrative about how she *helped* some poor trans kid make it in an industry that isn't always kind to anything other than cis hetero people, when the truth is that she made me ashamed of who I am. She made it impossible for me to talk about it with anyone, including my moms.

"I hate—I really, really hate—that it took the threat of her outing me to make me do this myself. I hate that this couldn't be my choice. But Weaver and Prime Records took so much from me already. They don't get to have this, too."

Melog headbutted Catra's temple, surprising her for a moment. She laughed softly before taking another breath and looking back at the camera. "So, here it is. My name is Catra, and I'm a transgender lesbian. When I was a kid, I used to dream about maybe making a difference in the world by being a famous queer musician, and how amazing it would be for other kids to see themselves in someone who was succeeding. I know it's probably too late for that now, but if even one person sees this and feels a little better, then it's worth it."

She sighed, looking at her hands. "Music has always been something therapeutic for me. It's another thing the label took me from me, and another thing I'm trying to take back. The music that's been running in the background this video is a mash-up of different covers I did for old songs that I used to relate to, and maybe still do. The piano accompaniment is a friend who'd prefer to remain nameless. This isn't meant to be a comeback video or anything—I don't think I want to be part of that again. But it's something I wanted to do for myself, and for the four or five people who watch the video through to the end. If you made it this far, thank you for listening to

my ramblings. There's a link in the description to a playlist of all the songs I used. Make good choices, and get a professional lawyer to read any contracts before you sign. See ya."

The video finished uploading, and Catra slammed her laptop shut, swallowing hard. "I think I'm gonna throw up."

"Deep breaths," Adora said, rubbing her back. "It's okay. The hardest part is over, right?"

Catra nodded, leaning into Adora. "Yeah. Thanks for...for all of this. I know it's a lot."

"Nothing to thank me for. I'm glad I could help."

She really was too good of a person, Catra thought as she curled closer, resting her head on Adora's shoulder. "Scorpia thinks we should all get brunch together some time," she said after a moment. "You know, Best Friend Squad and Super Pal Trio team-up."

"That sounds loud."

"That's what I said." Catra laughed. "Maybe we could just go without them."

Adora was silent for a few moments, and Catra was sure she had messed up. "Just us?" she finally asked. Catra nodded, staring determinedly at the wall. "I think I'd like that."

"Yeah?"

"Yeah."

Adora woke up to a floof of hair in her face.

Spending the night at Catra's had been an accident—it had been too late to consider driving home by the time they noticed. There

hadn't been any talk of Adora using the guest room, though; Catra had dragged her straight back to her room, and they'd flopped into bed together. Now Catra was resting on her chest, ear over Adora's heart, expression peaceful. Adora smiled, brushing her hair back, and reaching for her phone. Catra wanted to upload the video and forget it existed, but Adora couldn't help herself.

"Oh my god."

The words were barely a whisper, but Catra still stirred, lifting her head and blinking groggily. "What?" she mumbled, looking up at Adora, who was staring at her phone in disbelief. Adora scrolled a bit, mouth hanging open. "*What*?"

"Your video." Catra wilted slightly, ducking her head. "It has over a million views and six thousand comments."

"How many of them are telling me to fuck off?"

"Almost none, actually." Catra looked up, eyebrows furrowed. Adora started reading. "*The more I hear about that god awful company, the more I regret giving them my money.' I'm so sorry you had to go through that, your manager sounds like a terrible person.' Everyone should boycott that fucking book so she doesn't sell even one copy.' Thank you for sharing this, I'm sure it must have been scary*"…

Catra slowly lifted herself until she could see Adora's phone screen, and began reading for herself.

I'm glad you had good parents to help you get through all of that

Making you hide part of yourself is so shitty and you SHOULD complain

Some casual transphobia on top of some casual homophobia, fuck those people

You have the best cat

Catra wasn't sure whether to laugh or cry. So she did both, burying her face in Adora's shoulder. Adora set the phone aside to hold her tight.

"You okay?"

"Yeah." Catra's voice cracked, but she was smiling. "Yeah. I think I am."

Lyra lost her bet with Cyra. She bought the new car anyway.

Posting that video had lifted a weight off Catra's shoulders. She was smiling more, laughing more easily, and just seemed *lighter*. She and Adora had their first brunch date a few days later, and didn't get halfway through before Catra kissed her. Adora wasn't complaining.

There were downsides, of course. Magazines and talk shows were reaching out to Catra once more, all wanting her story. She told all of them the same thing—if they wanted to hear it, they could watch the video. Pictures were taken here and there, and Catra didn't *enjoy* it by any means, but it was bearable. Adora made it easier.

And the publishing company canceled Weaver's book. That alone made the entire thing worth it.

"Checkmate, bitch," she said happily as she closed the article on her phone and snuggled into Adora's side.

"If we're dating, do you have to do some big announcement or something?" Adora asked curiously. Catra tilted her head slightly to look up at her.

"*If* we're dating? I gave you a key to my elevator. You've practically moved in. Total lesbian stereotype, by the way. I knew you were just using me to get a roommate."

"I'm not here *that* much." Catra pointed to Princess, who was asleep on an overstuffed dog bed in the corner. Melog was sitting at the very top of his tree, tail swooshing through the air as he watched the intruder. Their first meeting had consisted of Princess trying to play and Melog swiping at her nose. It hadn't gotten much better from there. "I don't like leaving her home alone overnight."

"She has her own *crate* here. Just admit you're moving in."

"Are you *asking* me to move in?" Adora teased. "Cause I will if you ask."

"I am *not* asking."

"Then I'm not saying anything."

Princess had separate food and water bowls here and her own bin of food, but *okay*. Catra rolled her eyes. "No, I don't have to make a big announcement or anything. People can use their brains and figure it out for themselves if they care enough."

"If someone asks, can I tell them we're dating?"

Catra narrowed her eyes. "Are you asking for future reference, or because it's already happened?"

"*I* did not say anything. Glimmer, though…"

Of course. "Yes, you can tell people we're dating. You can shout it from the rooftops. I don't care."

"Be right back."

"No!" Catra yanked Adora back to the couch and practically crawled on her. "I'm not letting my pillow go. Shout it from the rooftops tomorrow."

"*Fine*." Adora huffed a petulant, put out sigh. Catra settled back into her comfortable position, closing her eyes.

“Oh, I’m getting a new phone number by the way . Try to keep the media off my back. Make sure you let me fix it in your phone. I’d hate for you to leave me for the next stranger you accidentally call in the middle of the night.”

“V ery funny.”

Chapter End Notes

And of course there's a playlist for the songs:

https://open.spotify.com/playlist/24UAT G7CKG j1sGS8H92? si=5766ef536543460c

They're mostly songs about being trans/forced to hide yourself in some way/not being ashamed of who you are.... etc.

And this is the official end of the story, for reals. Thank you all for your patience with my uncertainty about the existence of a third chapter, and I hope this was a satisfying way to close things out.

End Notes

Soooooooo review, maybe? Please?

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!